The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called The Array of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya

Āryākṣobhyatathāgatasyavyūhanāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 50 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་དེ་བཞིན་གཤེགས་པ་མི་འཁྲུགས་པའི་བཀོད་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པོའོ།།

The Array of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya, known in Sanskrit as the Akṣobhyatathāgatasya Vyūha and in Tibetan as De bzhin gshegs pa mi 'khrugs pa'i bkod pa, is a Great Vehicle sūtra presented as the sixth chapter of the Heap of Jewels collection. It opens with the Buddha staying on Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, accompanied by a great assembly of twelve hundred and fifty monks, all of them arhats. The discourse concerns the buddha Akṣobhya, whose name means the Immovable One. It recounts the vows he made as a bodhisattva and describes the splendid buddha realm, traditionally called Abhirati, that arose from those aspirations. This text is Toh 50 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the Heap of Jewels section, a large anthology of Mahāyāna sūtras.

From the Noble Great Heap of Jewels, the Dharma discourse in a hundred thousand chapters, the sixth chapter: The Array of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya. The first fascicle.

In the language of India: ārya akṣobhya tathāgatasya byūha nāma mahāyāna sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called The Array of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was staying at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, together with a great Saṅgha of monks, one thousand two hundred and fifty monks. All of them were arhats. Their defilements were exhausted and they were free of afflictions. They had attained mastery. Their minds were well liberated, and their wisdom was well liberated. They were thoroughbreds, great elephants. They had done what had to be done and accomplished their task. They had laid down the burden and attained their own goal. The fetters binding them to existence were utterly exhausted. Their minds were well liberated through perfect knowledge, and they had reached the supreme perfection of every mastery of mind. All were such, with the exception of a single person: the trainee and stream-enterer, the venerable Ānanda.

Surrounded by a great many bodhisattva great beings, by the Four Great Kings, by Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, by Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, and by other gods of great splendor besides them, as well as by nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, mahoragas, humans and nonhumans, and facing them, the Blessed One was teaching the Dharma.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Śāradvatīputra rose from his seat, draped his robe over one shoulder, and placed his right knee on the ground. Bowing toward the Blessed One with his palms joined, he said to the Blessed One:

"Venerable Blessed One, please explain well the entry, the conduct, the enthusiasm, and the generation of the mind of awakening of the bodhisattva great beings of the past who truly set out for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening; that generation of the mind by which the bodhisattva great beings of the past came to be truly set out for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, together with their armor and a full account of their qualities.

"Venerable Blessed One, please also explain well the deeds of those bodhisattva great beings of the past, their generation of the mind of awakening, their armor, and a full account of their qualities.

"Venerable Blessed One, please also explain the conduct of those bodhisattva great beings who strive for the welfare, benefit and happiness of the world with its gods, of such bodhisattva great beings as these, and a full account of their pure qualities.

"That will bring benefit to many people and happiness to many people; it will be compassion for the world, and it will bring welfare, benefit and happiness to the great multitude of beings, to gods and humans. For the bodhisattva great beings of the present and of the future as well, it will provide illumination with this light of the lamp of the Dharma and with this light of the Buddha, and it will also bestow encouragement.

"That being so, when persons of the bodhisattva vehicle hear of the entry, the conduct, the enthusiasm, the generation of the mind of awakening, the armor, and the full account of the qualities of those bodhisattva great beings of the past, they will train in the same way and practice in the same way. By training in that way and practicing in that way, they will become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening; and having come to possess such qualities, they will go on to attain, higher and ever higher, qualities that

are exceedingly distinguished."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra:

"Excellent, Śāradvatīputra, excellent! Śāradvatīputra, you have set out to care for the bodhisattva great beings of the future, and your intention to ask about the entry, the conduct, the enthusiasm, the generation of the mind of awakening, the armor, and the full account of the qualities of the bodhisattva great beings of the past is, once again, excellent of you. Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, listen well and closely, and keep it properly in mind, for I shall explain this concerning the bodhisattva great beings of the past."

The venerable Śāradvatīputra replied, "So be it, Blessed One," and listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One said to him:

"Śāradvatīputra, there is a world called Abhirati. There the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha called Great Eye dwells, lives and abides, and he teaches the Dharma to the bodhisattva great beings in this way, concerning the six perfections."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra thought: "I will be sure to ask the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha about this matter: in which direction is that world called Abhirati, where the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha called Great Eye teaches the Dharma to the bodhisattva great beings in this way, concerning the six perfections?"

Then the Blessed One, knowing with his mind the thoughts in the venerable Śāradvatīputra's mind, said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra:

"Śāradvatīputra, a thousand buddhafields to the east of this buddhafield there is a world called Abhirati. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha called Great Eye dwells, lives, and abides there, and he teaches the Dharma to the bodhisattva great beings in this way, concerning the six perfections.

"Śāradvatīputra, at that time, on that occasion, a certain monk rose from his seat, draped his robe over one shoulder, and set his right knee on the ground. He bowed with palms joined toward the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Great Eye, and said this to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Great Eye: 'Venerable Blessed One, I wish to train in the bodhisattva training just as it has been laid down.'

"Śāradvatīputra, when he had made this request, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Great Eye said this to that monk: 'Monk, nowadays it is extremely difficult to train in the bodhisattva training just as it has been laid down. Why is that? Because, monk, a bodhisattva must be unperturbed toward all sentient beings, and must not give rise to a mind of malice.'

"Śāradvatīputra, when he had said this, the monk said this to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Great Eye: 'Venerable Blessed One, from this day onward, with words free of guile and free of deceit, with true words, with words that do not change, I shall bring forth the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. I shall bend my mind toward unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and I shall also dedicate it fully.

"'Venerable Blessed One, I bring forth this precious arising of the mind of omniscience in this way. Having thus dedicated and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, if from now on, until I have fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should give rise to a mind of anger, of malice, or of agitation toward even a single sentient being, then let it be that I have deceived all those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, and abide, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incalculable worlds of the ten directions.

"'Venerable Blessed One, I bring forth this precious arising of the mind of omniscience in this way. Having thus dedicated and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, if from now on, until I have fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should be parted from the mind of omniscience with any single step I take, then let it be that I have deceived all those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, and abide, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incalculable worlds of the ten directions.

"'Venerable Blessed One, I bring forth this precious arising of the mind of omniscience in this way. Having thus dedicated and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, if, until I have fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should give rise to the mind of a śrāvaka or the mind of a pratyekabuddha, then let it be that I have deceived all those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, and abide, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable,

incalculable worlds of the ten directions.

"'Venerable Blessed One, I bring forth this precious arising of the mind of omniscience in this way. Having thus dedicated and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, if, until I have fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should give rise to a mind possessed of sensual desire, then let it be that I have deceived all those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, and abide, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incalculable worlds of the ten directions.

"'Venerable Blessed One, I bring forth this precious arising of the mind of omniscience in this way. Having thus dedicated and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, if, until I have fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should give rise to a mind possessed of attachment, or possessed of aversion, or possessed of delusion, or possessed of harmfulness, or possessed of sleep, or possessed of torpor, or possessed of regret, or possessed of restlessness, then let it be that I have deceived all those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, and abide, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incalculable worlds of the ten directions.

"'Venerable Blessed One, I bring forth this precious arising of the mind of omniscience in this way. Having thus dedicated and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, if, until I have fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should give rise to a mind possessed of doubt, then let it be that I have deceived all those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, and abide, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, incalculable worlds of the ten directions.

"'Venerable Blessed One, I bring forth this precious arising of the mind of omniscience in this way,

and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, if, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, I should give rise to a thought associated with killing, then may I have deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who are presently dwelling, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma in all the world systems of the ten directions, immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and beyond reckoning.

"Venerable Blessed One, having thus generated this precious resolve to attain omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, if, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, I should give rise to a thought associated with taking what is not given, or with unchaste conduct, or with lying, or with slander, or with harsh speech, or with idle talk, or with covetousness, or with malice, or with wrong view, then may I have deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who are presently dwelling, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma in all the world systems of the ten directions, immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and beyond reckoning." Thus he spoke.

Śāradvatīputra, a certain monk then thought, "Oh, how truly wonderful it is that bodhisattvas, great beings, from the very moment they don the great armor of first generating the resolve, are not agitated and not perturbed in mind toward any sentient being! Oh, this monk will come to be called Akṣobhya, the Imperturbable. Excellent!"

Śāradvatīputra, when that monk's name had thus become Akṣobhya, Akṣobhya, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye rejoiced in that name of his, saying, "Excellent, monk, excellent! Monk, while you practice the conduct of a bodhisattva, you will have this very name, and, monk, when you have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, you will have this same name too, namely Akṣobhya, Akṣobhya."

The Four Great Kings, Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, and Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, also rejoiced in that name of his, saying, "Excellent, monk, excellent! Monk, while you practice the conduct of a bodhisattva, you will have that very name, and, monk, when you have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, you will have this same name too, namely Akṣobhya, Akṣobhya."

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, who was present there, addressed the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye as follows: "Venerable Blessed One, having thus generated this precious resolve to attain omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, if, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, I should fail to act just as I have said, then may I have deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who are presently dwelling, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma in all the world systems of the ten directions, immeasurable, countless,

inconceivable, and beyond reckoning.

"Venerable Blessed One, having thus generated this precious resolve to attain omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, if, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, I should fail, even with every single step I take, to generate the resolve for omniscience accompanied by keeping the buddhas in mind, then may I have deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who are presently dwelling, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma in all the world systems of the ten directions, immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and beyond reckoning.

"Venerable Blessed One, having thus generated this precious resolve to attain omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, if, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, I should fail, life after life, to go forth from home into homelessness, then may I have deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who are presently dwelling, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma in all the world systems of the ten directions, immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and beyond reckoning.

"Venerable Blessed One, having thus generated this precious resolve to attain omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, if, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, even after going forth life after life, I should fail to become a forest dweller, or fail to live on alms, or fail to wear robes from rag heaps, or fail to eat at a single sitting, or fail to refuse food offered afterward, or fail to accept whatever food is obtained, or fail to dwell in charnel grounds, or fail to dwell in the open, or fail to dwell at the foot of a tree, or fail to remain sitting, or fail to accept whatever seat is given, or fail to keep only the three robes, or fail to wear garments of felt, or fail to have few desires, or fail to be content, or fail to long for the Dharma, or fail to delight in the Dharma, or fail to revere the Dharma, or fail to rely on the Dharma, or fail to teach the Dharma, and so on through the qualities of training and of ascetic purification, and

and the vows of having few possessions, if I do not dwell in them, having taken them up, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, having gone forth life after life, I do not teach the Dharma, or am not endowed with unobstructed eloquence, or am not endowed with immeasurable eloquence, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, apart from the three postures of standing, sitting, and walking, I should lie down, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if toward any sentient being whatsoever I should give rise to a thought that would lead to a root downfall, or a thought that involves a root downfall, or a thought involving women, or involving lying, or involving speaking otherwise than that, or involving harming and disparaging others, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, when teaching the Dharma to women in terms of the aspect of impermanence, or the aspect of suffering, or the aspects of emptiness and selflessness, or by way of various other aspects, I should take the various features of their limbs as attractive signs and show the row of my teeth, or laugh, or wave my hands, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and

teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, when teaching the Dharma, I should teach the Dharma while gesturing with my hands, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, when I see those who follow the Tathāgata, who have shaved their hair and beards, whether they have become fit vessels or not, it making no difference, and who wear the Tathāgata's banner, the saffron robes, I do not regard them as the Tathāgata, or as a stupa of the Tathāgata, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, when I see other bodhisattvas, I do not regard them as the Teacher, then may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live, remain, and teach the Dharma in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

Venerable Blessed One, having thus given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience, and having thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, when the Dharma is being explained and there are teachers of the Dharma present, I do not listen to the Dharma, then, in all the immeasurable world systems of the ten directions,

countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions, may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who presently dwell there, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience in this way, and I have dedicated it in this way to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, dedicating it fully. Until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if, apart from the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, I should ever bow to ascetics, brahmins, or other gods outside of this teaching, then throughout all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions, may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who presently dwell there, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience in this way, and I have dedicated it in this way to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, dedicating it fully. Until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if I should ever give rise to a perception that discriminates among sentient beings, thinking, 'To this one I will give, but to that one I will not give,' then throughout all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions, may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who presently dwell there, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience in this way, and I have dedicated it in this way to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, dedicating it fully. Until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if I should ever give rise to such a perception as, 'To this one I will present offerings, but to that one I will not present offerings,' then throughout all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions, may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who presently dwell there, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience in this way, and I have dedicated it in this way to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, dedicating it fully. Until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if I should ever give rise to such a thought as, 'To this one I will give the gift of the sacred

Dharma, but to that one I will not give it,' then throughout all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions, may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who presently dwell there, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have given rise to this precious resolve for omniscience in this way, and I have dedicated it in this way to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, dedicating it fully. Until I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, if I should ever see some sentient being who is condemned to death being led away, and I do not give up my own body in order to set him free, then throughout all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable, and incalculable world systems of the ten directions, may I have deceived those buddhas, the blessed ones, who presently dwell there, living, abiding, and teaching the Dharma."

Śāradvatīputra, that bodhisattva, who had entered upon the conduct of a bodhisattva, also said, "If I see some sentient being who is condemned to death being led away, then as long as I have not set him free, I will not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening."

Then, Śāradvatīputra, a certain monk thought, "For what reason does this bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, hold the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, as his masters and as his authorities? Whoever holds the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, as masters and as authorities will himself become a master and an authority for the world with its gods, humans, and asuras."

Then, Śāradvatīputra, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Great Eye, knowing with his mind the thought in that monk's mind, said this to the monk: "Monk, it is so. It is just as you think. Monk, whoever holds the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, as masters and as authorities will, before long, become a master and an authority for the world with its gods, humans, and asuras. Moreover, monk, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have truly set out for unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening clad in such great armor will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening."

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, said this to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Great Eye:

"Venerable Blessed One, I have thus generated this precious generation of the mind set on omniscience, and I have thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. If, until I have fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should see monks, nuns, laymen or laywomen who have committed the fault of a transgression and accuse them of the transgression, saying, 'You have committed this offense,' then let me be one who has deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live and remain, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

"Venerable Blessed One, I shall strive and work so that in the buddhafield where I fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, not even the mere sound of a transgression by the śrāvakas will be heard or arise, in any way whatsoever, in any form whatsoever. I shall strive so that the buddhafield where I fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening will become pure, and so that it will come to possess every perfect quality there is.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have thus generated this precious generation of the mind set on omniscience, and I have thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. If, until I have fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I should emit semen, even in a dream, then let me be one who has deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live and remain, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

"Venerable Blessed One, I shall strive and work so that in the buddhafield where I fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, those sons or daughters of good family, followers of the bodhisattva vehicle and of the śrāvaka vehicle, who have left the household life and gone forth, will not emit semen, even in a dream.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have thus generated this precious generation of the mind set on omniscience, and I have thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. If, until I have fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, there should appear, in the buddhafield where I fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, women such as the women of

the present day, women with whatever faults women have, and such faults of women, then may I not fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and let me be one who has deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live and remain, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

"Venerable Blessed One, I have thus generated this precious generation of the mind set on omniscience, and I have thus dedicated it and fully dedicated it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. If, until I have fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I do not act just as I have said, then let me be one who has deceived all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who now dwell, live and remain, and teach the Dharma, in all the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable and incalculable world systems of the ten directions.

"Bodhisattvas who possess this seed-dharma accomplish the qualities of a buddha in just the way they bring forth their resolve, and in just that way they also come to teach the Dharma." So he declared.

"Śāradvatīputra, then a certain monk said to the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, 'Excellent being, if this pledge you have made is a true aspiration, and if it is true that you will be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, then by this truth and these words of truth, with the big toe of your right foot make this great earth of the great trichiliocosm world system shake, shake strongly, shake strongly everywhere; move, move strongly, move strongly everywhere; quake, quake strongly, and quake strongly everywhere!'

"Śāradvatīputra, then at that time the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, through the might of the Buddha and through the power generated by the root of virtue of his own truthful pledge, made this great earth of the great trichiliocosm world system shake in six ways with the big toe of his right foot: he made it shake, shake strongly, shake strongly everywhere; move, move strongly, move strongly everywhere; quake, quake strongly, and quake strongly everywhere.

"Śāradvatīputra, in this way the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, acted just as he had said. Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening should train in accordance with the conduct of the bodhisattva, the

great being Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, bodhisattva great beings who train in accordance with the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, will take up just such a buddhafield, and will swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One:

"Venerable Blessed One, when that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya first truly set out on producing the mind of awakening, how many classes of gods gathered?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, when that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya first truly set out on producing the mind of awakening, all the Four Great Kings of the great trichiliocosm world system, Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, Māra the Evil One, Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, and all the many sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and in the form realm gathered together. With joined palms they bowed and spoke these words: 'Oh! We have heard these great lion's roars, never heard before, from the proclamation of this bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya!'

"Then, Śāradvatīputra, those sons of the gods, filled with joy and gladness, also said with one voice, 'Venerable Blessed One, those sentient beings who will be born in the buddhafield where this bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya will have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening have roots of virtue that are not of meager worth. And those sentient beings who hear this discourse on the Dharma of the great lion's roar, the great fearlessness of the bull, and the great aspiration also have roots of virtue that are not of meager worth.'"

When this had been said, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, I have never before heard of any other bodhisattva great being having such great armor as the great armor of that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya that the Tathāgata has described."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is. So it is, just as you have said. Śāradvatīputra, the great aspiration with which that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya, having donned great armor, truly set out for unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and a bodhisattva like him who, having donned that great armor, truly sets out for unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, are rare even among many hundreds of bodhisattvas, many thousands of bodhisattvas,

many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas, and many hundreds of thousands of ten millions of billions of bodhisattvas. Śāradvatīputra, the qualities that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya possesses are not found even among all the bodhisattvas of the Fortunate Eon.

"Śāradvatīputra, then the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied of that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya, 'Son of noble family, in a future time you will become the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha, perfect in knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed guide of beings to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One called Akṣobhya.' Śāradvatīputra, it was just as the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara prophesied of me, 'You will thus attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.'

"Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya's unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, this entire great trichiliocosm world system was pervaded by a great light, and that great earth quaked in six ways: it moved, moved strongly, and moved strongly everywhere; it trembled, trembled strongly, and trembled strongly everywhere; it rocked, rocked strongly, and rocked strongly everywhere. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: this entire great trichiliocosm world system was pervaded by a great light, and this great earth quaked in six ways: it moved, moved strongly, and moved strongly everywhere; it trembled, trembled strongly, and trembled strongly everywhere; it rocked, rocked strongly, and rocked strongly everywhere.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied that bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya's unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, all the trees, grasses, shrubs, medicinal herbs, and forests in that great trichiliocosm world system bowed, bowed deeply, and bowed down completely toward where the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya who had received the prophecy was. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: all the trees, grasses, shrubs, medicinal herbs, and forests in this great trichiliocosm world system bowed, bowed deeply, and bowed down completely toward where I was."

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great mahoragas, and humans and nonhumans dwelling in that great trichiliocosm, that world system of a billion worlds, turned toward wherever the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya, who had been prophesied, was. They joined their palms, bowed, and remained there paying homage. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great mahoragas, humans and nonhumans dwelling in the world of this great trichiliocosm turned toward wherever I was. They joined their palms, bowed, and remained there paying homage.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, all the women who were pregnant in that great trichiliocosm gave birth at that time easily and auspiciously. Beings who were blind saw forms with their eyes. Deaf beings heard sounds with their ears. Insane beings regained their mindfulness. Beings with impaired faculties came to possess all their faculties. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: all the women who were pregnant in this great trichiliocosm gave birth at that time easily and auspiciously, blind beings saw forms with their eyes, deaf beings heard sounds with their ears, insane beings regained their mindfulness, and beings with impaired faculties came to possess all their faculties.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, at that time not a single being in that great trichiliocosm died a wretched death. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: at that time not a single being in this great trichiliocosm died a wretched death.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, delightful divine fragrances arose throughout that great trichiliocosm. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I

fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: delightful divine fragrances arose throughout this great trichiliocosm.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said this to the Blessed One: "Venerable Blessed One, oh! Since the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya came to possess such qualities at the very moment he was prophesied in this way, the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya is endowed with great and excellent qualities."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke thus to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya, the qualities proclaimed were by no means limited to those alone. Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya has also reached the far shore of other, boundless qualities.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, at the time when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, all who dwelt in the great trichiliocosm, gods, humans and asuras alike, were joyful in mind and happy at heart. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: all who dwelt in this great trichiliocosm, gods, humans and asuras alike, were joyful in mind and happy at heart.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, at the time when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, all the Vajrapāṇis, lords of the yakṣas, who dwelt in the great trichiliocosm followed after him. Śāradvatīputra, it was just as when I fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience: all the Vajrapāṇis, lords of the yakṣas, who dwelt in this great trichiliocosm followed after me.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, at the time when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas who dwelt in that great trichiliocosm, the world system of a billion worlds, scattered, strewed, and showered divine flowers, perfumes, and incense over the place

where the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, was, in order to honor him. It was just as, Śāradvatīputra, when I fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas who dwell in this great trichiliocosm scattered, strewed, and showered divine flowers, perfumes, and incense over the place where I was, in order to honor me.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, two hundred million humans and three hundred million gods in that great trichiliocosm gave rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied all of them to unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, that entire great trichiliocosm was completely covered with blue lotuses, lotuses, white water lilies, and white lotuses. It was just as, Śāradvatīputra, when I fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, the seat of awakening was completely covered with blue lotuses, lotuses, white water lilies, and white lotuses.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of gods stood in the sky above, and in order to honor the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, they cast down many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of divine garments over the place where the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, had been prophesied, and spoke these words: "Oh! May this bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening!" It was just as, Śāradvatīputra, when I fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of gods stood in the sky above and, in order to honor me, cast down many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of divine garments over the place where I was.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, parents do not rejoice in a son as much as the world of that great trichiliocosm, with its gods, humans, and asuras, rejoiced. It was just as, Śāradvatīputra, when I fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, parents do not rejoice in a son as much as the world of this great trichiliocosm, with its gods, humans, and asuras, rejoiced.

The second section.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, through the power of the Buddha all the gods and humans who dwelt in that great trichiliocosm heard the prophecy of the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya. And having heard that prophecy, the beings of the desire realm gave gifts and also made merit; that is, they gave gifts of many kinds of food, snacks, and delicacies. Śāradvatīputra, it is just as, for example, on the full-moon day of the last autumn month of the four months, at the time of the Kaumudī festival, the beings of the desire realm give gifts and make merit, giving gifts of many kinds of food, snacks, and delicacies. Likewise, Śāradvatīputra, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Great Eye prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being Akṣobhya, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, the beings of the desire realm of that great trichiliocosm also gave gifts and made merit, making gifts of many kinds of food, snacks, and delicacies. And hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of gods played hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of divine cymbals, and also raised cries of "alala" and shouts of laughter.

"Śāradvatīputra, in this way, when the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya received his prophecy, he came to possess such qualities."

When the Blessed One had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, it is marvelous how the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, with the subtle knowledge of a tathāgata, have explained this so well. Venerable Blessed One, the domain of a buddha, the domain of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is inconceivable. The domain of meditative concentration of those who meditate is also inconceivable. The domain of the nāgas is also inconceivable. The karmic maturation of actions is

also inconceivable. Venerable Blessed One, the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya took up such special qualities from the very moment he first generated the mind of awakening. And, venerable Blessed One, the prophecy of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya, who possesses such qualities, is also inconceivable."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is; so it is. It is just as you have said. Śāradvatīputra, the prophecy of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya is inconceivable."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Venerable Śāradvatīputra, the Tathāgata has only spoken of a small portion, in summary, of the praises of the qualities of the armor of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya's first generation of the mind of awakening. He has not taught them in detail."

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the venerable Ānanda, "Venerable Ānanda, so it is. Venerable Ānanda, what the Tathāgata has taught of the praises of the qualities of the armor of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya's first generation of the mind of awakening is only a small portion. Why is that? Venerable Ānanda, it is because the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya possesses inconceivable qualities of the armor of his first generation of the mind of awakening. Therefore, venerable Ānanda, lend your ear and listen, and the Blessed One will teach it in detail."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, the Blessed One has spoken only in summary of the qualities of the armor of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya's first generation of the mind of awakening, and of its benefits. Venerable Blessed One, for the sake of caring for the bodhisattvas of the present and the future, may the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, please teach very well and explain in detail the praises of the qualities of the armor of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya's first generation of the mind of awakening."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, although the praise of the qualities of the armor of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya's first generation of the mind of awakening is inconceivable, nevertheless, Śāradvatīputra, I shall teach a small portion of it. So listen well and carefully, and keep it properly in mind, and I shall explain."

The venerable Śāradvatīputra said, "Venerable Blessed One, so be it," and listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then said to him:

"Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya generated this resolve, thinking, 'The element of space itself might possibly change, but I shall not let my vow change.' Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya donned the armor of such a great armor.

"Śāradvatīputra, among the bodhisattvas of the Fortunate Eon I do not see even a single bodhisattva who has donned great armor such as the great armor donned by the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, whatever conduct the bodhisattva great being Ratnaketu has does not approach even a fraction of the conduct of the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, the great armor that the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya donned is not found even among many hundreds of bodhisattvas, many thousands of bodhisattvas, many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas, or many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of bodhisattvas.

"Śāradvatīputra, because the bodhisattva great being Akṣobhya thus took up such great and steadfast diligence, he fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, and as the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Akṣobhya, he now dwells, lives and abides in the world system called Abhirati, and teaches the Dharma.

"Śāradvatīputra, I know directly that when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, whenever anyone asked him for a hand, a foot, his head, an eye, or any of his limbs or minor limbs, there was nothing whatsoever that he did not give."

"Śāradvatīputra, from the time he first generated the mind of awakening until he fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya never once suffered a headache. He was never struck by any illness arising from wind, from bile, from phlegm, or from their combination. Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, this marvelous and wondrous quality also arose in him.

"Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya formerly practiced the conduct of a

bodhisattva, in all his lives he pleased the tathāgatas and never displeased them. In every life he practiced the holy life, and in every life he bore that very same name, Akṣobhya. He went from buddha field to buddha field, and he was born in each of those places where the buddhas, the blessed ones, were present in person.

"Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. A wheel-turning king, a kṣatriya anointed on the crown of his head, may go from palace to palace, yet he does not walk upon the great earth with the soles of his feet. Dwelling on the upper floors of those excellent palaces, he plays, delights, and enjoys himself with the five qualities of sense pleasure, until his life comes to its end.

"Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, in all his lives he pleased the tathāgatas and never displeased them. In every life he practiced the holy life, and in every life he bore that very same name, Akṣobhya. He went from buddha field to buddha field, and although he was born in each of those places where the buddhas, the blessed ones, were present in person, he did not go to those buddha fields with the soles of his feet.

"Whatever Dharma he taught, he taught all of it on the basis of the perfections themselves; only rarely did he teach on the basis of the śrāvaka ground. Even when he taught the Dharma on the basis of the śrāvaka ground, he taught all of it on the basis of the perfections themselves. When he taught the Dharma on the basis of the pratyekabuddha ground, he likewise taught all of it on the basis of the perfections themselves. By teaching the Dharma on the basis of the perfections themselves, he trained sentient beings toward awakening, brought them into it, and firmly established them in it. Taking unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening as his theme, he instructed them, inspired them to take it up, roused their enthusiasm, and filled them with delight. Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, he was endowed with such a great armor of steadfast diligence.

"He also fully dedicated the root of virtue of that gift of Dharma to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, saying: 'Oh! Through this root of virtue, when I have fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and teach the Dharma, may all the sons and daughters of good family belonging to the bodhisattva vehicle who appear in that buddha field

hear this teaching of the Dharma through the power of the Buddha. Having heard it, may they retain it, keep it, recite it, and master it, and may they teach it extensively and correctly to others as well. In their later lives, too, may they not forget those teachings. Just as I now go from buddha field to buddha field, may the bodhisattva great beings born there likewise be born in whichever buddha fields they aspire to, and until they fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, may they never be separated from the buddhas, the blessed ones.' Excepted from this are the bodhisattva great beings bound to one more birth who have been born in the abode of Tuṣita.

"Why is that? Śāradvatīputra, this is the nature of things: bodhisattva great beings in their final existence die and pass from the realm of the Tuṣita gods, and in their last body they are conceived in the womb through the mother's right side. For, Śāradvatīputra, when bodhisattva great beings in their final existence are born, the great earth itself quakes.

"Śāradvatīputra, these are the aspects, these are the signs, and these are the marks of a bodhisattva great being in his final existence. Śāradvatīputra, when a bodhisattva great being in his final existence enters his mother's womb, he is not soiled by impure and foul-smelling things, nor does he perceive any unpleasant odors there. Even while the bodhisattva dwells in the womb, he abides in space.

"Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. A monk who practices yoga and possesses miraculous powers may enter an upper chamber, or a series of upper chambers, rise up into the open sky, and remain there in his postures, yet he does not touch that upper chamber. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, when a bodhisattva great being in his final existence dwells in his mother's womb, he remains raised up in space. He abides unsoiled by the impurities of the womb and by impure and foul-smelling things, nor does he perceive any unpleasant odors there."

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, was formerly engaged in the conduct of a bodhisattva, he thought: "Right now, while I engage in the conduct of a bodhisattva, no māra at all can find an opening against me. In the same way, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, may any sons and daughters of good family who appear in that buddha field, whether they follow the bodhisattva vehicle or the śrāvaka

vehicle, also be beyond the reach of Māra and the gods of Māra's realm. From the time they engage in the conduct of a bodhisattva until they have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, may Māra and those gods find no opening against them in any way whatsoever, in any respect whatsoever. And for as long as those bodhisattvas have not fully attained those perfect qualities, may I too go on practicing for the sake of awakening."

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, was formerly engaged in the conduct of a bodhisattva, whenever he taught the Dharma or listened to the Dharma, his body never once grew weary, nor did his mind. Why was that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, from the time that Tathāgata first gave rise to the mind of awakening, while he engaged in the conduct of a bodhisattva, he thoroughly cultivated the Dharma body.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, was formerly engaged in the conduct of a bodhisattva and was listening to the Dharma, he thought: "Just as I now long for the Dharma, so too, in the buddha field where I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, may the sentient beings not be without longing for the Dharma, but may they long for the Dharma."

From the Mahāyāna sūtra The Prophecy of Akṣobhya, the first chapter.

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, has spoken well in praising the qualities of the bodhisattva conduct that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya formerly practiced. Now, Venerable Blessed One, please also teach, extensively and thoroughly, the array of buddha-field qualities found in the present buddha field of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Why do I ask this? So that sons and daughters of good family who follow the bodhisattva vehicle, having heard of the array of qualities of that buddha field, will strive to be born in that buddha field. So that they will also develop the wish to see that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and to pay homage to him, make offerings to him, attend upon him and please him. And so that, when sons and daughters of good family who follow the śrāvaka vehicle and have

not yet entered the flawless state hear of the array of qualities of that buddha field, they too will develop the wish to see that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and to pay homage to him, make offerings to him, attend upon him and please him."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Excellent, Śāradvatīputra, excellent! Śāradvatīputra, it is excellent that you think to ask about the perfect array of buddha-field qualities found in the buddha field of that Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, listen well and closely, and keep it in mind, for I shall explain the perfect array of buddha-field qualities found in the buddha field of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya."

Śāradvatīputra replied, "So be it, Blessed One," and listened as the Blessed One instructed. The Blessed One then said this to him:

"Śāradvatīputra, at that time all the sentient beings in that great trichiliocosm world system knew that seven days from then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya would fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Knowing this, none of those beings had any thought of food at all. No perception of hunger arose in them, no perception of thirst, no perception of lying down in bed, and no perception of weariness of body or mind. Instead, all those beings were endowed with the perception of happiness. They were endowed with the perception of joy and of supreme joy, with contentment of mind, and with ease of mind. Why was that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, through the special power of the aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya made when he was formerly engaged in the conduct of a bodhisattva, all of them came to possess such qualities.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, at that time the humans and the gods of the desire realm dwelling in that world system knew that seven days from then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya would fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Knowing this, they had no thought of engaging in sexual intercourse at all. Why was that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the special power of the aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya made when he was formerly engaged in the conduct of a bodhisattva."

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, that entire great trichiliocosm world system was pervaded by a great light, and the great earth shook in six ways. It shook, shook strongly, and shook strongly everywhere. It trembled, trembled strongly, and trembled strongly everywhere. It rocked, rocked strongly, and rocked strongly everywhere. It was agitated, strongly agitated, and strongly agitated everywhere. It rumbled, rumbled strongly, and rumbled strongly everywhere. It resounded, resounded strongly, and resounded strongly everywhere. Śāradvatīputra, this was because the buddhafield in which the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience came to possess the array of qualities of a buddhafield.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, all the gods and humans dwelling in that great trichiliocosm world system remained facing toward the seat of awakening, their palms joined, paying homage. Śāradvatīputra, this too was because the buddhafield in which the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience came to possess the array of qualities of a buddhafield.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, the arrays of qualities that came to be possessed by the buddhafield in which the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, and, Śāradvatīputra, the arrays of qualities that the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya now possesses, are not found even among many hundreds of buddhas, many thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of buddhas, or many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of buddhas. Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the distinctive aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made formerly, while he practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva. Śāradvatīputra, the arrays of qualities of buddhafields are accomplished through distinctive

aspirations, just as, Śāradvatīputra, when I formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, things came to be just as I had made my aspirations.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, in that instant, in that moment, in that very second, he became visible within the range of sight of all the sentient beings dwelling in that great trichiliocosm world system, both those who had the divine eye and those who did not. Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the distinctive aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made formerly, while he practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya went to the seat of awakening, fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, and attained the wisdom of omniscience, the evil Māras did not give rise to the thought, "Why should we not overpower this Tathāgata, Arhat, Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, so as to obstruct his full awakening into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening?" Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the distinctive aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made formerly, while he practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of gods of that great trichiliocosm world system stationed themselves in the sky above, and in order to make offerings to the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, they scattered, strewed, and showered down divine flowers, divine perfumes, divine incense, divine garlands, divine sandalwood, divine powders, divine music, divine garments, divine parasols, divine victory banners, divine pennants, and divine jewel ornaments toward where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya was, and they devoted themselves to the work of offering.

As soon as they had scattered them, through the power of the Buddha, those divine flowers, divine perfumes, divine incense, divine garlands of flowers, divine sandalwood, divine powders, divine musical instruments, divine

garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine pennants, and divine jewel ornaments became, in the sky directly above the crown of the head of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, a parasol endowed with the finest of all qualities, about a hundred yojanas in size, and there it remained. Śāradvatīputra, that too came about through the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and attained the wisdom of omniscience, the light from the body of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya outshone the light of the sun and the moon, dimming them so that they could not be seen. Instead, the light of the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya filled the entire trichiliocosm, the great thousandfold world system, with a great radiance.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, the light of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya outshone the light of the sun and moon of that trichiliocosm, the great thousandfold world system, and even the light of all the gods, dimming them so that they no longer appeared even within the range of sight. Śāradvatīputra, that too came about through the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, oh, how wonderful it is that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, in the past, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, donned such great armor, and that his special aspirations became so vast! How wonderful that in the past, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he established in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of billions of trillions of living beings, beyond measure, beyond counting, inexpressible, more inexpressible than the inexpressible; and that whatever roots of virtue he had, those roots of virtue of generating the mind of awakening, he dedicated to unsurpassed, perfect and complete

awakening for the sake of purifying a buddha field, and that exactly as he dedicated them, just so were his aspirations fulfilled!"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is; so it is. It is just as you have said. Śāradvatīputra, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, in the past, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, did don the great armor.

"Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddha field of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, the tree of awakening at whose foot the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya sat, fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and attained the wisdom of omniscience, is made of the seven precious substances and is a hundred thousand yojanas high. Its trunk is a hundred yojanas high and half a krośa around. Its branches each extend seven thousand yojanas, and its full circumference is forty thousand yojanas. When the branches, leaves, and twigs of that tree of awakening are stirred by the wind, sweet, pleasing, and enchanting sounds arise from them. Śāradvatīputra, sounds as sweet, pleasing, and enchanting as those that arise when the branches, leaves, and twigs of that tree of awakening are stirred by the wind would not arise even from divine musical instruments with a hundred thousand parts played by skilled master musicians.

"From that tree of awakening arise the sounds of all the perfections, the superknowledges, the faculties, the powers, the factors of awakening, and all the branches of the path, far surpassing divine voices, soft and pleasing. All the sentient beings who hear those sounds attain the meditative absorption called Mindfulness of the Mind Free from Attachment.

"Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, listen well and closely to the description of the array of qualities of the buddha field of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, and keep it properly in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

The venerable Śāradvatīputra said, "Excellent, Blessed One," and listened as the Blessed One instructed, and the Blessed One said this to him.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, there are none of the three lower realms. What are the three? They are the hells, the animal

kingdom, and the world of Yama. All the beings who have been born there possess the ten virtuous courses of action, every one of them.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield beings are not divided into master and servant. Śāradvatīputra, the people of that buddhafield have no inclination to busy themselves with ordering others about. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, the beings in that buddhafield do not grasp at a self or at anything as belonging to a self.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, the whole great ground of that buddhafield is as level as the palm of the hand. It is pleasant to the touch, like kācalindika cloth, and has the color of gold. It is adorned with divine jewels and beautifully ornamented with golden lotuses having a thousand koṭis of petals. Mandārava and great mandārava flowers are strewn over it. There are no tree stumps, thorns, gravel, or pebbles; no ravines, cliffs, or places where filth is dumped; no rocks and no mountains. Śāradvatīputra, when one sets one's foot on that great ground, it gives softly beneath it, and when one lifts one's foot, it springs back. Śāradvatīputra, it is just like a well-stuffed cotton pillow: when one lays one's head on it, it gives softly, and when one lifts one's head, it springs back. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, when one sets one's foot on that great ground it gives softly, and when one lifts one's foot it springs back.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, the people of that buddhafield have no illnesses whatsoever arising from wind, from bile, from phlegm, or from their combination. Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, among the people of that buddhafield there is no ugly complexion and no unpleasant odor at all. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, the beings of that buddhafield have little attachment, little aversion, and little delusion.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield those beings are never, in any way whatsoever, subjected to killing, binding, or imprisonment.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield there are no abodes of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) whatsoever, in any form at all.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield the trees are always in flower and always bearing fruit, every one of them.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield the clothing of the people consists of garments of five colors that come from wish-fulfilling trees and serve them as clothes. These garments are bright in color and sweetly fragrant, and their colors never fade. Śāradvatīputra, just as the flowers of the

gods have their various fragrances, so too, Śāradvatīputra, is the fragrance of their garments. Whatever fragrance the garments have while they are on the wish-fulfilling tree, they keep that same fragrance once they have been plucked, and so the fragrance and color of those garments never deteriorate. Śāradvatīputra, because those people have garments in great number and abundance, they change their clothes again and again and put on fresh ones.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield, whatever kind of food those people desire, that very food appears before them in jeweled vessels. Śāradvatīputra, just as for the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three whatever food they think of appears, in the same way, Śāradvatīputra, in that world, whatever kind of food those people desire, that very food appears before them in jeweled vessels.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield, whatever food those people have is not inferior to the food of the gods in color, fragrance, or taste.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield those people have no feces, urine, spittle, or mucus. Śāradvatīputra, just as the gods who dwell in the desire realm have no feces, urine, spittle, or mucus, in the same way, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield those people have no feces, urine, spittle, or mucus.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield, through the special power of the former aspirations of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and through the maturation of those people's merit, such perfect arrays of the qualities of a buddhafield have come into being. Wherever those people are to dwell, there appear multistoried mansions made of the seven precious substances, and within those mansions, upon thrones made of the seven precious substances, cotton cushions well spread out. In those mansions, as part of the mansions' amenities, there appear pools of various kinds, filled with water endowed with the eight qualities, in which the people bathe. These pools, every one of them, are spread with golden sand and surrounded by divine aśoka trees. There the people dwell, delighting in the joy of the sacred Dharma. Śāradvatīputra, wherever those people wish pools filled with water endowed with the eight qualities to appear, right there, before those people, pools filled with water endowed with the eight qualities appear. If they wish them to follow along after them, they follow along; and if they wish them to vanish, they vanish.

Śāradvatīputra, in that buddha field winds arise that are neither too warm nor too cold. Winds arise that are soft, pleasant, and gentle. Winds arise that are fragrant and delightful, and these very winds serve as perfume for those people and those gods. If someone wishes for a breeze, thinking, "May a breeze blow upon me," a breeze blows upon him. If others do not wish it, the wind does not touch their bodies, and whenever they do wish it, a breeze blows upon them. Śāradvatīputra, this too is the perfect array of the qualities of the buddha field of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddha field there are none of the defects of women that are now counted as women's defects in my buddha field. Śāradvatīputra, what are they? In this buddha field women are of unpleasant complexion and unattractive form; they smell foul and are full of impurities; they are never satisfied with sensual pleasures; they are ungrateful; and they are overcome by anger, double-tongued speech, jealousy, and stinginess. Śāradvatīputra, these are the defects of women in this buddha field. Śāradvatīputra, in that buddha field women have no such defects as are counted as women's defects. Śāradvatīputra, this has come about through the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Śāradvatīputra, in that buddha field women possess every good quality. Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Just as the precious woman (strīratna) far surpasses the qualities of human women and possesses the qualities of a goddess, so, Śāradvatīputra, compare the qualities of the precious woman in this buddha field with the qualities of the women in that buddha field: the qualities of the precious woman do not come near even a hundredth part of theirs. They cannot bear comparison with even a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a part in a hundred koṭis, a part in a thousand koṭis, a part in a hundred thousand koṭis, or a part in a hundred thousand koṭi-niyutas; nor in number, fraction, reckoning, example, or cause.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddha field men do not join their bodies with women in order to engage in sexual intercourse. Śāradvatīputra, in that buddha field, when men give rise to a mind of attachment, they go and merely glance for a moment at a woman with a mind of attachment, and by that alone the man's desire is completely pacified. Thoroughly disenchanted, he gives it up, and through contemplating the unattractive he attains the samādhi of

freedom from desire. Freed by that samādhi from the noose of Māra, he will never again give rise to a mind of desire. The woman whom that man looked at becomes pregnant merely from being looked at, and when the desire of both has been pacified, the boy or girl dwelling in the womb also experiences in body and mind a bliss like this: just as the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three experience bliss in body and mind when they rejoice and delight supremely in their jeweled palaces, so it is, Śāradvatīputra, for the boys and girls dwelling in the womb in that buddha field. There, having experienced bliss for seven days and nights, those dwelling in the womb are born. The pregnant woman, too, experiences such bliss in body and mind, just as all monks absorbed in the second dhyāna are blissful in every way. When that woman gives birth, there is no impurity or foul smell. Śāradvatīputra, this too has come about through the special aspiration that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, saying, "Ah, when I fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, may that buddha field of mine possess such qualities!"

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddha field of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, whenever men, women, boys, or girls wish to wear ornaments, the wish-fulfilling trees bow down and adorn them. Śāradvatīputra, this too has come about through the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Then a certain monk, having heard the praise of that buddha field and the qualities of those women, gave rise to a mind of attachment toward them and said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, may I too take birth in that buddha field!"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to that monk, "A deluded man like you will not be born in that buddha field. Why is that? Because no one can be born in that buddha field with a mind stirred up by desire. Rather, monk, it is through virtuous conduct, the conduct of the Dharma, the holy life, and right conduct that beings take birth in that buddha field."

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddha field, apart from the knowledge that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya himself is the unsurpassed King of Dharma, there is no other king

whatsoever.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Just as the people of Uttarakuru have no other king, so too, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield there is no other king at all. The people know only that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya himself, is the unsurpassed king of the Dharma.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Just as the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three gather in order to serve Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), so too, Śāradvatīputra, the gods and humans of that buddhafield gather in order to behold the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, to pay homage to him, to make offerings to him, to honor and serve him, and to listen to the Dharma. Śāradvatīputra, this too comes from the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield the people all dwell in a state of conscientiousness. Why is that? Śāradvatīputra, it is because their guide, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya himself, laid down the cause for it beforehand. Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva in the past, he offered flowers, incense, fragrances, garlands, ointments, powders, garments, parasols, victory banners, and pennants to the stupas of the tathāgatas and to images of the tathāgatas. Then he made this aspiration: "Through this root of virtue, may my buddhafield be endowed with the best of everything in every way!" Because he made that aspiration, it has now become just so. Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, those people have no buying and selling, no trade, no farming, and no agriculture. Instead,

those people live in perfect happiness.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, the people of that buddhafield do not sing songs in voices full of desire in order to amuse themselves with sensual pleasure. Instead, those people experience the joy of the Dharma.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, when the rows of golden palm trees are stirred by the wind, a sound arises that is melodious, sweet, delightful, and captivating. Śāradvatīputra, such a melodious, sweet, delightful, and captivating sound as arises from the rows of golden palm trees when they are stirred by the wind would not arise even from divine instruments of the fivefold music played by a skilled master musician. Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the special aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to bring to perfection the array of qualities of a buddhafield should do as the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya did when he practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva in the past. Just as he took up the excellent array of qualities of a buddhafield and purified a buddhafield, so one should take up the excellent array of qualities of a buddhafield, and so one should purify a buddhafield.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the sun and the moon do not do much work of giving light. Yet there is no darkness there, and no gloom either. Why is that? Śāradvatīputra, it is because the light of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya constantly illuminates that entire great trichiliocosm, the world system of a billion worlds.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose a precious jewel were placed inside a walled, many-storied mansion whose doors are closed, whose windows are shut, which is covered above and below, and which is plastered with fine clay. When that precious jewel gives light there by the radiance of its own body, the beings who live there perceive light by day and perceive light by night as well. In just the same way, Śāradvatīputra, the light of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya constantly

illuminates all of that great trichiliocosm.

Śāradvatīputra, in this example, "the walled, many-storied mansion" is a figure for the world system called Abhirati. Śāradvatīputra, "the precious jewel" is a figure for the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Śāradvatīputra, "the light of that precious jewel" is a synonym for the light of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, "sentient beings" is a synonym for the people who dwell in that buddhafield.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, wherever the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya goes, at each and every place on the great earth where he sets his feet, golden lotuses with a thousand petals spring up. Śāradvatīputra, this too has come about through the special power of the aspirations the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya enters a house, do golden lotuses with a thousand petals spring up from beneath his feet even then?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya seldom goes into villages and towns. Yet whenever he does go and stays there, golden lotuses with a thousand petals spring up in that house.

"Śāradvatīputra, if some son or daughter of good family there should think, 'May all these lotuses that sprang up beneath the feet of the Tathāgata when he came into this house gather together in one place,' then by the power of the Buddha they gather together in one place. And if one should think, 'May they rest in the sky,' then by the power of the Buddha they rest in the sky. Śāradvatīputra, those lotuses also become shrines for the people of that great trichiliocosm, that world system of a billion worlds.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in that great trichiliocosm, wherever the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened

Buddha Akṣobhya goes in order to teach the Dharma, there too such lotuses spring up. And in whatever other directions and other world systems the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya sends forth emanations, there too, by the power of the Buddha, such lotuses spring up. Śāradvatīputra, in this way that entire great trichiliocosm is constantly adorned with nothing but such golden lotuses with a thousand petals.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya there are stairways made of gold, silver, beryl, and the seven precious substances, which are set up from Jambudvīpa and reach as far as the realm of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. Śāradvatīputra, whenever the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three wish to see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, to pay homage to him, and to honor and serve him, they descend from the realm of the Thirty-Three by those jeweled stairways. Then those gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three give rise to a longing for the people of Jambudvīpa, thinking: 'There is the divine excellence of us gods, and there is the human excellence of the people of Jambudvīpa. Not only are these excellences of the people of Jambudvīpa not inferior in the slightest degree to the excellences of us gods, but on top of that, here in Jambudvīpa the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya dwells, teaching the Dharma, and so they far surpass us.' In this way the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three long for the state of the people of Jambudvīpa.

"Śāradvatīputra, when the people of Jambudvīpa climb up to the abode of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, they feel no longing for the gods of the Thirty-Three. Why is that? Because they think: 'Not only are our excellences not inferior to the divine excellences of these gods, but on top of that, in our Jambudvīpa the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya dwells, teaching the Dharma, and so by this excellence of our Buddha we outshine these gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three.'

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield the gods see the humans, and the humans also see the gods. Thus the people of Jambudvīpa, while remaining right there in Jambudvīpa, can also see the celestial palaces of the gods of the desire realm. Śāradvatīputra, it is just as the people of this

Jambudvīpa now see the forms of the stars, and the sun and the moon. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, by the power of the Buddha, the people of Jambudvīpa in that buddhafield see the celestial palaces of the gods of the desire realm. Śāradvatīputra, this too has come about through the special power of the aspirations the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past, while he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva."

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, as for the buddhafield of that Blessed One (the Buddha), the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya: when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya teaches the Dharma throughout that entire great trichiliocosm, that great trichiliocosm is never empty of the four assemblies. Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the special aspirations of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, made when he formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva.

This concludes the second chapter of the Great Vehicle sūtra The Prophecy of Akṣobhya.

Fascicle three.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya teaches the Dharma, with every single teaching of the Dharma he trains measureless and countless sentient beings in this way so that they realize the fruit of arhatship. Śāradvatīputra, in this manner measureless and countless sentient beings are trained so that they realize the fruit of arhatship, and for the most part they are all meditators absorbed in the eight liberations.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya is measureless and countless. Śāradvatīputra, I truly do not see any accountant or great accountant at all who could count or reckon them with numbers and calculations, and comprehend them, saying, "There are this many surpassings," or "There are this many fullnesses," or "There are this many enfoldings," or "There are this many boundless supremes," or "There are this many karandas," or "There are this many overpowerings," or "There are this many ther-bums," or "There are this many immeasurables." Rather, Śāradvatīputra, those śrāvakas come under the number "measureless" itself, or "countless" itself. Or else they come under a number counted only by the

wisdom of omniscience.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield the sons of good family who remain in the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of once-returning, or the fruit of non-returning are few. Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. For example, when I now teach the Dharma, a lazy stream-enterer who does not attain any higher distinction is one who will have at most seven more existences, and I teach that he will have at most seven existences. In the same way there, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya teaches the Dharma, those sons of good family who, while sitting on a single seat, do not attain the fruit of arhatship at once, but attain the fruit of stream-entry through the first teaching of the Dharma, the fruit of once-returning through the second teaching, the fruit of non-returning through the third teaching, and the fruit of arhatship through the fourth teaching, are what is called "lazy" there.

Śāradvatīputra, unlike how it is now, whoever is a stream-enterer there is not one who has at most seven existences; rather, he realizes arhatship in that very body. Thus the establishing of a fruit called "stream-entry" is nothing more than a name. Unlike how it is now, whoever is a once-returner there does not return once to this world and then make an end of suffering; rather, he realizes arhatship in that very body. Thus the establishing of a fruit called "once-returning" is nothing more than a name. Unlike how it is now, whoever is a non-returner there does not come there once and then pass into complete nirvāṇa; rather, he realizes arhatship in that very body. Thus the establishing of a fruit called "non-returning" is nothing more than a name.

Śāradvatīputra, whoever is an arhat there does not abide there, does not abide here, and does not abide in between where neither is; he passes into complete nirvāṇa in the element of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates. Śāradvatīputra, in this way, in that buddhafield, that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya adopts this establishing of the fruits and teaches the fruits of the ascetic life.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, whatever son or daughter of good family there knows the Dharma abides on the ground of training and does not decline. Śāradvatīputra, there the "ground of training" is a synonym for "the ground of dregs." Śāradvatīputra, such a one passes into complete nirvāṇa relying on the ground of no more training, and passes into complete nirvāṇa abiding on the ground of no more training. Śāradvatīputra, there the "ground of no more

training" is a synonym for "arhatship." Śāradvatīputra, this is called the excellence of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, which abides in the essence of purity.

Śāradvatīputra, there "the excellence of abiding in the essence of purity" is a synonym for the Saṅgha of the śrāvakas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya: arhats whose defilements are exhausted, who are free of afflictions, who have attained mastery, whose minds are thoroughly liberated, whose wisdom is thoroughly liberated, thoroughbreds, great elephants, who have done what was to be done, who have accomplished their task, who have laid down the burden, who have attained their own aim, who have utterly exhausted the fetters binding them to existence, whose minds are thoroughly liberated through perfect knowledge, who have gone to the supreme far shore of all mastery of mind, and who for the most part are meditators absorbed in the eight liberations. Śāradvatīputra, that is the excellent array of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas among the śrāvakas in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the śrāvakas do not think, "Where shall we take our meal today? Who will give us food today?" Nor do those śrāvakas enter houses for alms. When the time for the meal has come, at that very moment food appears in their alms bowls. When those śrāvakas think, "It would also be good if others gave us food," then others will indeed give them food. With merely two or three mouthfuls they complete the act of eating and are satisfied.

Those śrāvakas do not go in search of alms bowls and robes. They do not cut their robes, do not sew them, do not wash them, and do not dye them; they neither do this themselves nor seek it from others. Instead, simply as much as they need for their use appears through the power of the Buddha.

Again, Śāradvatīputra, that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, does not teach the śrāvakas rules concerning transgressions in the way that I now teach the śrāvakas the rules of the four transgressions. Śāradvatīputra, that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, does not teach the śrāvakas rules of that kind. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, in that

buddhafield there is no degeneration of lifespan, no degeneration of beings, no degeneration of the times, no degeneration of views, and no degeneration of afflictions, and there is no failing of courage. Thus, Śāradvatīputra, that buddhafield is free of the degenerations.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, teaches the Dharma to the śrāvakas, from the very outset he teaches the most excellent teachings. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, the beings in that buddhafield all understand from the mere mention of a heading. Those who must be brought to understanding through elaboration, or through detailed explanation, are not found there.

Śāradvatīputra, in the śrāvaka Saṅgha there, there is not even a single one who has overweening pride. Śāradvatīputra, there even the mere name "one with overweening pride" is impossible.

Śāradvatīputra, in the śrāvaka Saṅgha there, whatever forms of the stains of an ascetic there may be, the faults of an ascetic, the crookedness of an ascetic, the deceit of an ascetic, and the trickery of an ascetic, all of these are entirely absent, utterly and in every way. Indeed, not even the mere name "stain of an ascetic" ever occurs. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, the roots of virtue of those beings are fully ripened and pure, and so they come to understand the Dharma exactly as it has been taught to them.

Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield there is absolutely no teaching of the five acts of immediate retribution; there not even the word "immediate retribution" is heard.

Śāradvatīputra, those śrāvakas are not intent on gain and honor, nor are they intent on alms bowls and robes. They are not in any way whatsoever intent on robes and requisites. Śāradvatīputra, there is no need to teach them the Dharma in order to turn them away from thoughts of gain and honor. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, the śrāvakas in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, have few desires and are content.

Again, Śāradvatīputra, that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, does not lay down training rules for the śrāvakas in the way that I now lay down training rules for the śrāvakas. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, those śrāvakas have no faults. The training there is this alone: recollecting emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness.

Śāradvatīputra, just as now some foolish people, having gone forth under my teaching, violate the foundations of my training, those śrāvakas do not violate the foundations of training. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, the assembly of śrāvakas in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, consists entirely of the discerning, and because, Śāradvatīputra, there are no degenerations in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

There, no śrāvaka lives together with another; each dwells diligently devoted to the aim of his own yoga. They delight in solitude and strive in the yoga of solitude; they constantly apply themselves to the side of virtue and do not seek gain and honor. Because the persons there are distinguished by unflagging diligence, the lazy are not to be seen there at all. Śāradvatīputra, the śrāvakas in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, are endowed with such perfected qualities.

Śāradvatīputra, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, teaches the Dharma to those śrāvakas, those śrāvakas listen to the Dharma with attentive ears, with undistracted eyes, and with undistracted minds. Those who listen to the Dharma standing feel no weariness of body or mind, and those who listen to the Dharma seated feel no weariness of body or mind.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya rises up into the sky by miraculous power and teaches the Dharma to the śrāvakas, then, through the power of the Buddha, both the monks there who possess miraculous powers and the monks who do not possess them likewise rise up into the sky by miraculous power and listen to the Dharma. And while those śrāvakas of the Blessed One remain risen up in that very sky, they also abide in the three postures. What are the three? They are standing, sitting, and walking. When they pass into complete nirvāṇa, they sit cross-legged in the sky and pass into complete nirvāṇa there.

"When all those śrāvakas pass into complete nirvāṇa, the great earth trembles everywhere. Even after they have passed into complete nirvāṇa, gods and humans honor them with acts of reverence. Some arhats there burn their bodies with the fire element of their own bodies and so pass into complete

nirvāṇa. Some arhats there, when they pass into complete nirvāṇa, make their own bodies vanish just as the wind does, and so pass into complete nirvāṇa.

"Śāradvatīputra, it is like this: when clouds of five colors have gathered and then dispersed, there is no rain and nothing is seen. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, some arhats there, when they pass into complete nirvāṇa, make their own bodies dissolve so that not even a fragment is seen.

"Śāradvatīputra, there are also some śrāvakas there who pass into complete nirvāṇa by this kind of passing. Some śrāvakas there rise up into the sky by miraculous power and send forth streams of water from their bodies. Without letting those streams of water fall to the ground, they cause them to subside into the sky, and in the same way, without letting their own bodies fall from the sky, they cause them too to subside there all at once. Śāradvatīputra, the śrāvakas there pass into complete nirvāṇa by such modes of passing into complete nirvāṇa.

"Śāradvatīputra, this too has come about through the special quality of the aspiration that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made formerly, when he was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, saying: 'Oh, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, may the śrāvakas in that buddhafield pass into complete nirvāṇa in this way, by the three kinds of miraculous display!'

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, among the countless śrāvakas of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, those śrāvakas who have not attained the four analytical knowledges are few, while those who have attained the four analytical knowledges are very many. The śrāvakas who have attained the four bases of miraculous power are also very many. Śāradvatīputra, the śrāvakas in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya are endowed with such excellent qualities."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, this great and excellent array of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, such as it is, is marvelous."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is, so it is. It is just as you have said. Śāradvatīputra, the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly

Complete Buddha Akṣobhya is endowed with such a great array, the excellent array of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas."

This concludes the third chapter of the Great Vehicle sūtra called The Prophecy of Akṣobhya.

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, the Blessed One has well described the excellent array of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, but the Blessed One has not described the excellent array of the bodhisattva qualities of the bodhisattvas in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Blessed One, please now explain well the excellent array of the bodhisattva qualities of the bodhisattvas. Why is that? Venerable Blessed One, it is so that from that, all those excellences that are the excellences of bodhisattvas may come about."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, in the world realm called Abhirati, there is at present a great assembly of bodhisattvas: many hundreds of bodhisattvas, many thousands of bodhisattvas, many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas, immeasurable hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of bodhisattvas, and countless bodhisattvas. Śāradvatīputra, all the bodhisattva great beings there who have gone forth under the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, through the power of the Buddha, take up the Dharma taught by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya; they retain it, recite it, and master it, and they also teach it extensively and correctly to others.

Śāradvatīputra, the Dharma that I am now teaching is no more than a tiny portion of the Dharma. Śāradvatīputra, the Dharma taught by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya is immeasurable and countless. Compared with that teaching of the Dharma, this Dharma that I teach does not come near even a hundredth part of it. It does not come near a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a part in a hundred koṭis, a part in a thousand koṭis, a part in a hundred thousand koṭis, or a part in a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas. It cannot bear comparison by number, by fraction, by counting, by example, or by cause.

Even compared with the Dharma that the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya will teach once he has fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, and with the Dharma that all the buddhas, the blessed ones, of the Fortunate Eon will teach, the Dharma taught by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya is immeasurable and countless. Compared with that teaching of the Dharma, the teachings that all the buddhas, the blessed ones, of the Fortunate Eon will give do not come near even a hundredth part of it. They do not come near a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a part in a hundred koṭis, a part in a thousand koṭis, a part in a hundred thousand koṭis, or a part in a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas. They cannot bear comparison by number, by fraction, by counting, by example, or by cause.

Śāradvatīputra, this too came about through the distinctive force of an aspiration. In the past, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he made this aspiration: "Oh, when I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, I will teach the Dharma to whatever bodhisattvas, great beings, appear in that buddhafield. May they, through the power of the Buddha, retain, uphold, recite, and master all those teachings of the Dharma, and teach them extensively and correctly to others as well!"

Śāradvatīputra, in this way, through the power of the Buddha and through the maturation of their own roots of virtue, those bodhisattvas, great beings, retain, uphold, recite, and master all the Dharma taught to them, and teach it extensively and correctly to others as well.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, if those bodhisattvas, great beings, wish to go to other buddhafields and other world systems in order to behold the tathāgatas, to pay homage to them, to attend upon them, and to listen to the Dharma, then as soon as they form that intention, through the power of the Buddha and through the strength generated by their own roots of virtue, they go to other buddhafields and other world systems. Having arrived in those buddhafields and those world systems, they pay homage to the buddhas, the blessed ones, bow down to them, show them reverence, hold them in high esteem, honor them, make offerings to them, question them, and inquire of them; and having heard the Dharma, they retain it and teach it to sentient beings. When they have paid homage to those buddhas, the blessed ones, bowed down to them, shown them reverence, held them in high esteem, honored them, made

offerings to them, questioned them, and inquired of them, and when, having heard that Dharma, they have retained it and also taught the Dharma to sentient beings, they return once more to the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Śāradvatīputra, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who wish to behold the nine hundred and ninety-six buddhas who will appear in this Fortunate Eon should also take birth in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Śāradvatīputra, whatever bodhisattvas, great beings, whether they pass away from this world system or pass away from other world systems, have been born, are being born, or will be born in that buddhafield are not destined to fall to the level of the śrāvakas or to the level of the pratyekabuddhas. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, those bodhisattvas are without exception to be known as resembling the realization of the Tathāgata; those bodhisattvas are to be known as being like the Buddha's going forth; those bodhisattvas are to be known as not to be trampled by any Māra the Evil One; those bodhisattvas are to be known as having cut off any link to the level of the śrāvakas and the level of the pratyekabuddhas; and those bodhisattvas are to be known as linked to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this: when bodhisattvas gather together, it should be known that this is a gathering of tathāgatas, a gathering that is wholly firm and indestructible like a vajra.

Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattvas of the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya are all pure, abiding in the essence, of an irreversible nature, of a nature that cannot be carried off, and of a nature that cannot be turned back. They are certain of awakening, unshaken and unmoving from awakening, and those bodhisattvas should be known as all abiding in the state of irreversibility from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Śāradvatīputra, whatever bodhisattvas, great beings, whether they pass away from this world system or pass away from other world systems, have been born, are being born, or will be born in that buddhafield should all be known to have entered the treasury of the Tathāgata.

They should be understood to have entered the city of fearlessness.

Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield those bodhisattvas, moreover, engage in talk connected with the perfection of wisdom, and they regard one another as the Teacher.

Śāradvatīputra, moreover, among the bodhisattva great beings of that buddhafield, those who live as householders are very few. For the most part, the bodhisattvas of that buddhafield have left the household life and are renunciants, one and all.

Śāradvatīputra, moreover, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya teaches the Dharma, those bodhisattva great beings, through the power of the Buddha and by bringing forth the strength of their own roots of virtue, retain, uphold, recite, and fully master all those teachings of the Dharma.

Śāradvatīputra, those bodhisattva great beings who have left the household life but have not gathered at that teaching of the Dharma and are not bodily present there also hear all those teachings, through the power of the Buddha, from the very place where they are standing or sitting. Having heard them, they retain, uphold, recite, and fully master them.

Śāradvatīputra, those lay bodhisattva great beings who have not left the household life and are not bodily present at that teaching of the Dharma, wherever they may be standing or sitting, also hear all those teachings through the power of the Buddha, while still standing there and while still sitting there. Having heard them, they retain, uphold, recite, and fully master them.

Those bodhisattva great beings will not forget those teachings even in later lives. Whatever buddhafield they wish to be born in, in that very buddhafield they will be born. Śāradvatīputra, this too is the perfect array of the qualities of a buddhafield in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Why is that? It is because it has come about through the distinction of his former aspirations.

Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to see, in a single lifetime, many hundreds of buddhas, many thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of buddhas, should be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, as soon as that bodhisattva great being is born there, he will see many hundreds of buddhas, many thousands of buddhas, many hundreds

of thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of buddhas, and he will also cultivate many roots of virtue in the presence of those buddhas, those blessed ones. He will also teach the Dharma to many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of living beings, and he will lead them, through their roots of virtue, to generate the mind set on unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Śāradvatīputra, moreover, suppose that one bodhisattva great being in this present Fortunate Eon honors, venerates, respects, and makes offerings to all the nine hundred and ninety-six buddhas who will appear in it, with robes, alms food, bedding, medicine for the sick, remedies, and every requisite. Having honored, venerated, respected, and made offerings to them all, he leaves the household life and goes forth in the presence of those buddhas, those blessed ones, and practices the holy life. And suppose that another bodhisattva great being, in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, produces within a single lifetime an accumulation of merit endowed with the perfections. Śāradvatīputra, the former accumulation of merit does not come near even a hundredth part of this latter accumulation of merit. It cannot bear comparison with a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a part in a billion, a part in ten billion, a part in a trillion, or a part in hundreds of thousands of millions of billions; it cannot bear comparison by number, by fraction, by counting, by analogy, or by cause.

Śāradvatīputra, this too is the perfect array of the qualities of a buddhafield in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Śāradvatīputra, whatever bodhisattva great beings, whether they die and pass on from this world system or die and pass on from other world systems, have been born, are being born, or will be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, all of them will receive the prophecy of their irreversibility from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield there are no obstructing māras present, nor gods of the māra class, no deeds of māra are present, and no harassment occurs.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose, for example, that a man, by the power of a mantra or by the power of a medicine, renders a venomous snake free of

venom and then releases it. As soon as it is released, since it is unable to seize, harass, or harm, the other kinds of living beings have no fear of it, and it does not harass or obstruct even a single being. Nevertheless, Śāradvatīputra, that body of its, produced through the formation of its past karma, still bears the name "venomous snake."

Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya was formerly practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he dedicated his roots of virtue in just such a way, thinking, "Once I have become fully and perfectly awakened, may I tame the māras, the evil ones, and make them harmless, so that afterward too there will be no one who creates obstacles." Because of this, when the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya became fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, in that great trichiliocosm there was no obstacle whatsoever, in any respect, for those bodhisattvas, those śrāvakas, and those ordinary beings.

Yet, Śāradvatīputra, in that buddhafield, those who through the karma of their former formations have been born as gods of the class of the Paranirmitavaśavartin heaven (the gods who control the emanations of others) receive the name "māra." They disparage that name and that birth, and they listen to the teaching of the Dharma. Having heard it, they gain faith, and they also rejoice in those śrāvakas, thinking, "When will we too come to dwell with so few desires, with such contentment, and in such solitude?" In this way those māras come to have thoughts conducive to renunciation, and they conduct themselves without creating obstacles. Śāradvatīputra, that too is the perfection of the array of qualities of the buddhafield in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Śāradvatīputra, through the former aspirations, the former diligence, and the former human effort of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, all the bodhisattva great beings, the śrāvakas, and those ordinary beings in that buddhafield dwell endowed with great happiness.

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One: "Venerable Blessed One, suppose some son or daughter of good family who delights in that buddhafield, who wishes to turn away from the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and who wishes to enter the state of

certainty, were to fill this great trichiliocosm with the seven precious substances and give it as a gift. Since by giving that gift they would be born in that buddhafield, that gift would be well given. And why? Because such a one would not be destined to turn back to the state of a śrāvaka or of a pratyekabuddha. Why is that? Because such a one would come to abide on the ground of non-regression, and until becoming fully awakened into perfect and complete awakening would go from buddhafield to buddhafield; everywhere would please the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas who appear before them; everywhere would seek the awakening of a buddha; would see many hundreds of buddhas, many thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of buddhas, and many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of buddhas; and would cultivate roots of virtue with those buddhas, those blessed ones. Venerable Blessed One, in this way, if some son or daughter of good family, in order to be born in that buddhafield, were to fill this great trichiliocosm with the seven precious substances and give it as a gift, and if by giving that gift they were born in that buddhafield, then, Venerable Blessed One, it has been well given, well bestowed, and they have been well born. That bodhisattva great being has gone well to that buddhafield."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Śāradvatīputra, so it is; it is just as you have said. Śāradvatīputra, because such beings have gone well and been born well, that buddhafield is filled with bodhisattva great beings.

"Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose there were a vein of gold free of gravel and pebbles, free of stones and dust, consisting of pure essence. Gold is extracted from it, smelted and refined with a pair of bellows, and once smelted and refined it is made into various other ornaments and worn on the body. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great beings in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya all without exception consist of pure essence. Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great beings gathered in the buddhafield of that Tathāgata Akṣobhya should be known to be pure.

"Śāradvatīputra, all those who have been born, are being born, or will be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya are counted among those called 'pure beings.' All of them are counted among those called 'irreversible.' All of them are counted among those called 'having a single support,' that is, 'relying on the Tathāgata.'

"Śāradvatīputra, if one asks how a bodhisattva great being has a single support: Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great being who relies on the Tathāgata is called one with a single support. Furthermore, 'having a single support' is a designation for what is called 'having utterly passed beyond all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.'"

Śāradvatīputra, therefore a bodhisattva great being who wishes to attain reliance upon the Tathāgata, which is the single support, should be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great beings whom I have prophesied as irreversible should also be born in the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great beings whom I have sent into the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya have not been abandoned by me.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose a king, a kṣatriya consecrated on the crown of his head, who has attained might, strength and vigor, sets out to fight against a rival king and goes to battle, out of desire for a kingdom, desire for wealth and desire for territory. Then he hears, "That rival king is coming to fight against you, out of desire for a kingdom, desire for wealth and desire for territory." Having heard this, the king thinks, "If I send all the jewels, the queens and their retinue, the sons and daughters, and the young ones who are unable to fight to where the royal army is, a place hard to overcome, they will dwell in comfort; but here they would suffer." Thinking this, he puts them away for safekeeping in another city.

Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, the bodhisattva great beings whom I have sent into the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya have not been abandoned by me either. Śāradvatīputra, just like the jewels, the queens and their retinue, the sons and daughters, and the young ones unable to fight whom the king, the kṣatriya consecrated on the crown of his head, put away for safekeeping, so should the sons and daughters of good family who belong to the bodhisattva vehicle be regarded. Śāradvatīputra, just like the city where the king's jewels, the queens and their retinue, the sons and daughters, and the young ones unable to fight were put away for safekeeping, so should the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya be regarded. Śāradvatīputra, just like the king who comes to fight, so should the

māras be regarded, who in this buddhafield are engaged in the work of creating obstacles for the sons and daughters of good family who belong to the bodhisattva vehicle, and are bent on doing them harm. Śāradvatīputra, just like the king who is mighty and hard to overcome, so should the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya be regarded, who cannot be overcome by Māra or by any of the gods of Māra's host.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose a man who is afraid and terrified of a creditor flees to a borderland city, where, once he has gone there, the creditor or the creditor's men will not be able to touch him. Why is that? Because the road by which the creditor or the creditor's men would come there is cut off. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, for the bodhisattva great beings who are born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the road of Māra the Evil One and of the gods of Māra's host is cut off.

Śāradvatīputra, in this great trichiliocosm world system, Māra the Evil One and the gods of Māra's host stay close by in order to create obstacles for the persons of the bodhisattva vehicle and the persons of the śrāvaka vehicle who dwell in this great trichiliocosm world system, and they set about doing them harm. Not so in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya: there the māras and the gods of Māra's host do not stay close by for the sake of Māra's work.

Moreover, Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great beings who have been born, are being born, or will be born in that buddhafield, those bodhisattvas will not become afraid in the slightest. Why is that? It is because the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, when formerly practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, dedicated his roots of virtue in just such a way that in the buddhafield where he would fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, the māras and the gods of Māra's host would not stay close by in order to create obstacles.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. An arhat whose defilements are exhausted dwells having attained ease and having attained fearlessness. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, all the bodhisattva great beings who have been born, are being born, or will be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya also dwell having attained ease and having attained fearlessness. They should be known to be thoroughly

guarded, protected and sheltered. Why is that? It is because that very guide, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, when formerly practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, generated his roots of virtue in just such a way that in the buddhafield where he would fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, Māra or the gods of Māra's host would not stay close by for Māra's work, nor enter in order to do harm.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose a man has taken an antidote and then drinks poison. Even if he treats that poison as food, it does him no harm and is digested well. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One (the Buddha), the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was formerly a bodhisattva practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he fully dedicated his roots of virtue so that in that buddhafield neither Māra nor the gods of Māra's class would engage in the work of Māra, and none would enter it to cause harm. Because he dedicated them in that way, Śāradvatīputra, that buddhafield possesses all such qualities.

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra thought, "Through the power of the Buddha, may we too behold that buddhafield, that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, that Saṅgha of śrāvakas, and that immeasurable, countless host of bodhisattvas."

Then the Blessed One, knowing with his mind the thought in the venerable Śāradvatīputra's mind, at that moment performed a display of miraculous power such that, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Śāradvatīputra, while still sitting on that very seat, saw that buddhafield and the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, together with his Saṅgha of śrāvakas and surrounded by his retinue, the host of bodhisattvas.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, do you see that buddhafield, that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, that Saṅgha of śrāvakas, and that immeasurable, countless host of bodhisattvas?"

He replied, "Venerable Blessed One, I see them. Sugata, I see them."

The Blessed One said, "Śāradvatīputra, do you see any distinction or difference at all between those gods and those humans in their necessities, their enjoyments, their play, and their delight?"

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra replied to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, I see no distinction or difference at all between those gods and those humans in their necessities, their enjoyments, their play, and their delight. Why is that? Venerable Blessed One, it is because in that buddhafield all necessities and enjoyments are themselves divine substances, and because that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya illuminates all the ten directions; like a golden pillar he is brilliant in splendor and auspicious, blazing with glory, his body beautifully adorned with the thirty-two marks of a great being and his form embellished with the eighty excellent minor marks, and he is seated in the midst of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas, teaching the Dharma.

"Venerable Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose some person is out in the great ocean. If he sets out eastward, he sees neither shore nor mountain; and so too to the south and to the west; if he sets out northward, he sees neither shore nor mountain. In the same way, Venerable Blessed One, when one is in the midst of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the last of the śrāvakas is not to be found to the east, the last of the śrāvakas is not to be found to the south, nor to the west, nor to the north.

"Moreover, Venerable Blessed One, they listen to the Dharma with their bodies unmoving and unstirring, just as if they were absorbed in meditative attainment. Venerable Blessed One, here the body of an arhat who is a meditator absorbed in attainment may still move, but those śrāvakas, when they listen to the Dharma, have no movement of the body. Venerable Blessed One, they listen to the Dharma with their bodies unmoving and unstirring, just as if they were absorbed in meditative attainment."

Fascicle Four.

"Venerable Blessed One, suppose some son or daughter of good family, in order to be born in that buddhafield, were to fill this great trichiliocosm with the seven kinds of precious things and give it as a gift, relinquishing it entirely; and suppose that through that relinquishment they were born in that buddhafield. Venerable Blessed One, that would be well given, well relinquished, and well born, and that bodhisattva great being would have gone well to that buddhafield. Why is that? Because such a one will attain the state of irreversibility."

The Blessed One said, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is. It is just as you have said. Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose a man in the service of a king whose edicts are mighty carries a letter stamped with the king's seal and goes to some village, town, market town, or region, whichever it may be. As he travels, no being at all, whether guards at the passes, toll collectors, boatmen, villagers, townspeople, road wardens, the king's men, wayfarers, travelers, or anyone else, obstructs his journey or harasses him; his road, both going and coming, is free of obstacles. Why is that? Because he bears the king's seal, he is seen to travel without obstacles.

"In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, it should be understood that all those bodhisattva great beings who have been born, are being born, or will be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, whether they have died and passed from this world system or from other world systems, are irreversible from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Until they fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, they will go from buddhafield to buddhafield. Everywhere they will please the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas. Everywhere they will seek the awakening of a buddha. Everywhere they will never be parted from the buddhas, the blessed ones, from the bodhisattvas, and from the śrāvakas of the buddhas. And they will swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening."

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, a stream-enterer here who abides in the fruit of stream-entry and those bodhisattva great beings born in that buddhafield are alike. Why is this? Just as a stream-enterer here who abides in the fruit of stream-entry has cut off the stream of falling into the lower realms, so too, Venerable Blessed One, all those bodhisattva great beings who have been born, are being born, or will be born in that buddhafield should be regarded as having cut off the stream of falling into the lower realms, and as having cut off all the stages of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Until they fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, they will go everywhere from buddhafield to buddhafield, and everywhere they will never be parted from the buddhas, the blessed ones, from the bodhisattvas, and from the śrāvakas of the buddhas."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, it is so; it is just as you have said. Śāradvatīputra, all those bodhisattva great beings who have been born, are being born, or will be born

in that buddhafield, whether they have died and passed from this world system or from other world systems, should be regarded as having cut off the stream of falling into the lower realms, and as having cut off all the stages of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Until they fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, they will go from buddhafield to buddhafield. Everywhere they will seek the awakening of a buddha. Everywhere they will please the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas who are present before them. And everywhere they will never be parted from the buddhas, the blessed ones, from the bodhisattvas, and from the śrāvakas of the buddhas.

"Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. For example, a stream-enterer is no longer subject to falling into the lower realms, and is certainly bound for perfect awakening. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, it should be understood that all those bodhisattva great beings who have been born, are being born, or will be born in that buddhafield, whether they have died and passed from this world system or from other world systems, are certain to attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Until they fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, they will go from buddhafield to buddhafield. Everywhere they will please the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas. Everywhere they will seek the awakening of a buddha. And everywhere they will never be parted from the buddhas, the blessed ones, from the bodhisattvas, and from the śrāvakas of the buddhas."

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, a once-returner here who abides in the fruit of once-returning and a bodhisattva great being born in that buddhafield are alike. Venerable Blessed One, a non-returner here who abides in the fruit of non-returning and a bodhisattva great being born in that buddhafield are also alike. Venerable Blessed One, an arhat here who abides in the fruit of arhatship and a bodhisattva great being born in that buddhafield are also alike."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, do not say that! Śāradvatīputra, do not say that either! Why is this? Because, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being here who has received the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and a bodhisattva great being born in that buddhafield are alike; and a bodhisattva great being here who has attained acceptance that phenomena are unborn and a bodhisattva great being born in that buddhafield are alike. Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being here who is seated at the seat of

awakening and a bodhisattva great being born in that buddhafield are also alike.

Why is that? Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great beings born in that buddhafield should be known to rely on the Tathāgata. They should be known to be beyond the reach of the māras and the gods of Māra's class. Those bodhisattvas should be known to have cut off any link to the level of the śrāvakas and the pratyekabuddhas. Until they have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, they will travel from buddhafield to buddhafield, and everywhere they will please the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas.

Then the venerable Ānanda thought, "What sort of eloquence does the Elder Subhūti have on this matter? I shall put the Elder Subhūti to the test."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the venerable Subhūti, "Elder Subhūti, let us behold the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya, together with his Saṅgha of śrāvakas and his assembly of bodhisattvas, and the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Akṣobhya."

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Ānanda, "Venerable Ānanda, do you see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya, together with his Saṅgha of śrāvakas and his assembly of bodhisattvas, and that buddhafield?"

Ānanda replied, "Elder Subhūti, we shall look."

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Ānanda, "Venerable Ānanda, look up at the sky!"

Then the venerable Ānanda looked up at the sky. Having looked, he said to the venerable Subhūti, "Elder Subhūti, when I look up at the sky, I see that the whole sky above is empty."

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Ānanda, "Venerable Ānanda, just as you see the whole sky above as empty, in the same way, venerable Ānanda, should you view the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya, together with his Saṅgha of śrāvakas and his assembly of bodhisattvas, and that buddhafield as well."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, the Blessed One has declared, 'The bodhisattva great being who

has received the prophecy here and the bodhisattva great beings born there are equal.' Venerable Blessed One, by what sameness are they equal?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, they are equal through the sameness of the dharmadhātu, the expanse of phenomena."

This concludes the fourth chapter of The Array of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya.

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra thought, "The venerable Blessed One has described the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya, as he formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva. He has also described the excellent array of qualities of his buddhafield, the excellent array of his Saṅgha of śrāvakas, and the excellent array of the qualities of his bodhisattvas. Yet the venerable Blessed One has not yet described the great parinirvāṇa of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya. So it would be fitting for the venerable Blessed One now to explain well what the great parinirvāṇa of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya will be like, and what signs will accompany it."

Then the Blessed One, knowing with his mind the reflection in the venerable Śāradvatīputra's mind, said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, on the day when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya passes into parinirvāṇa through the great parinirvāṇa, on that day the Tathāgata will emanate emanation bodies in order to teach the Dharma to the beings of that great trichiliocosm, that world system of a billion worlds. Those emanation bodies of the Tathāgata will then teach the Dharma to those beings in such a way that, through that teaching of the Dharma, they will train beings far more immeasurable and far more countless than all the beings he had trained through his earlier teaching of the Dharma. Among them, some beings will be trained in the Śrāvaka Vehicle, some in the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle, and some will be trained in the unsurpassed vehicle of the ten powers.

"Śāradvatīputra, then, at the time of his parinirvāṇa, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Akṣobhya will prophesy the unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening of the bodhisattva great being called Gandhahastin, saying, 'Noble one, seven days after my sacred Dharma has disappeared, you will fully awaken to

unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening here in this world system of Abhirati, and you will become the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, the one endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, the knower of the world, the guide who tames beings, the unsurpassed one, the teacher of gods and humans, the buddha, the Blessed One called Golden Lotus.'"

Śāradvatīputra, the excellent array of qualities in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Golden Lotus, will be just like the excellent array of qualities in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. And, Śāradvatīputra, the excellent array of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas and the excellent array of the assembly of bodhisattvas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Golden Lotus, will be just like the excellent array of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas and the excellent array of the assembly of bodhisattvas of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, with nothing more and nothing less.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, at the time of the great parinirvāṇa of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the great earth will quake in six ways. It will move, move strongly, and move strongly all over; it will shake, shake strongly, and shake strongly all over; it will quiver, quiver strongly, and quiver strongly all over. A great light will also appear in the world. In that great trichiliocosm a great sound will also arise, and that sound will be heard as far as the six classes of gods who dwell in the desire realm and the classes of gods up to Akaniṣṭha. Then, having heard that sound, the classes of gods who dwell in the desire realm and the classes of gods who dwell in the form realm will understand, thinking, "That Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, is about to pass into parinirvāṇa." They will take no delight in their own divine palaces, and such perceptions of discontent will arise in them. And they will say these words: "Alas! The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who has become the eye, who has become wisdom, who has become the sovereign, who has become the standard of what is valid, who has become the light, will vanish from the world all too soon!"

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, at the time of the great parinirvāṇa of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, all the jewel trees, wish-fulfilling trees, grasses, shrubs, medicinal

plants, and forests there are in that buddhafield will bow down toward the place where the great parinirvāṇa of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, takes place.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, through the former aspiration of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, he will establish the hundred and eight bases of the gateways of Dharma for the sake of the bodhisattva great beings who come later, saying, "Friends, these are the hundred and eight bases of the gateways of Dharma. After I have passed away, if those bodhisattva great beings who will be born in this buddhafield master these hundred and eight bases of the gateways of Dharma, they will master all dharmas and retain them all."

Thus, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, just as while he is present, so also after he has passed into parinirvāṇa, those bodhisattva great beings will master all dharmas, and until they have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, they will travel from buddhafield to buddhafield and behold the tathāgatas; and because they are irreversible, they are thoroughly sustained.

Śāradvatīputra, whatever bodhisattva great beings, whether they die and pass from this world system or die and pass from other world systems, have been born, are being born, or will be born in that buddhafield, all of them, just as while that Blessed One is present, so also after he has passed into parinirvāṇa, will attain the mastery of all dharmas.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, at the time of the great parinirvāṇa of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, through the power of the Buddha, that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, will appear before the eyes of beings dwelling in various other world systems.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, has passed into parinirvāṇa through the great parinirvāṇa, gods and humans, in order to honor his body, will scatter over his body the flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, flags, and jewel ornaments of gods and humans. The heap of those scattered flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, flags, and jewel ornaments of gods and humans will measure about a league in circumference and in height.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya passes completely into nirvāṇa by the great complete nirvāṇa, all the gods, humans, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas, however many there are in that great trichiliocosm world system, will bow toward the place where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya has passed into the great complete nirvāṇa, and will pay homage with palms joined.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya passes completely into nirvāṇa by the great complete nirvāṇa, those gods and humans will be pierced by the thorn of grief for seven days and nights. Crying, 'Alas! The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya has passed into nirvāṇa all too swiftly!' they will beat their breasts. Those gods and humans will feel no joy and take no part in play, nor will they indulge in sensual pleasures. With their minds absorbed in this way, those gods and humans will say to one another, 'Alas! The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who had become the eye, who had become wisdom, who had become mastery, who had become valid cognition, who had become the light, has vanished from the world all too swiftly!'

"Śāradvatīputra, whatever bodhisattva great beings, whether they have died and passed on from this world system or have died and passed on from other world systems, have been born, are being born, or will be born in that buddhafield, all of them should be understood to have been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Śāradvatīputra, those bodhisattvas cannot be counted by counting in hundreds. Rather, Śāradvatīputra, they come into the numbers called hundreds, thousands, or hundreds of thousands. Śāradvatīputra, just as those bodhisattva great beings come into the number of hundreds, the number of thousands, and the number of hundreds of thousands, in the same way, Śāradvatīputra, they should be regarded as being in the number of tathāgatas. They should be regarded as being in the number of buddhas. They should be regarded as being in the number of omniscience.

"Śāradvatīputra, whatever bodhisattva great beings, whether they have died and passed on from this world system or have died and passed on from other world systems, have been born, are being born, or will be born in that

buddhafield, all of them will come into just such a number; that is, they will come into that very number, the number of tathāgatas, the number of buddhas, and the number of omniscience.

"Śāradvatīputra, apart from the irreversible bodhisattva great beings, any other bodhisattvas who do not get to hear this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya should all be known to be under the sway of Māra.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya passes completely into nirvāṇa by the great complete nirvāṇa, his body will be consumed by its own fire element. His relics will be the color of gold, and where those relics are broken, śrīvatsa marks and coiled svastikas will appear and shine forth brilliantly. Śāradvatīputra, it is just as when a great tree of the kind called timisa is cut: where it is cut, śrīvatsa marks and coiled svastikas appear and come forth. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, where the relics of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who has passed into the great complete nirvāṇa, are broken, śrīvatsa marks and coiled svastikas will come forth, and they will display various miracles and various powers.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, where the relics of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who has passed into the great complete nirvāṇa, are broken, śrīvatsa marks and coiled svastikas will come forth. Śāradvatīputra, it is just as when the stone called mulaso is broken: where it is broken, śrīvatsa marks and coiled svastikas come forth. In the same way, Śāradvatīputra, from the broken pieces of the cut relics of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who has passed into the great complete nirvāṇa, śrīvatsa marks and coiled svastikas will also come forth.

"In order to honor those relics, beings throughout that entire great trichiliocosm world system will build stupas of the seven precious substances for them. That entire great trichiliocosm world system will be adorned in this way: just as the sky is filled with stars, so that buddhafield will always be adorned with stupas of the seven precious substances and with golden lotuses, each having a thousand koṭis of petals.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, when those bodhisattva great beings who are approaching the time of death pass away from there, signs such as these will appear. Those bodhisattva great beings will see the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas of the buddhafield in which they are to be reborn, and having seen them, they die without forgetting. When they have died, gods and humans will strive to honor their relics, and they will make offerings to the relics with all the splendor of gods and humans.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, the relics of those bodhisattva great beings gradually scatter into space and become subtle, until not even a fragment of them remains and they are no longer visible. Śāradvatīputra, it is like this: if wet grass is put into a fire, streams of smoke arise, and that smoke too gradually rises up into the sky, scatters in space and becomes subtle, until not even a fragment of it remains and it is no longer visible. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, the relics of those bodhisattva great beings who have passed away from that buddhafield also gradually scatter into space and become subtle, until not even a fragment of them remains and they are no longer visible.

Śāradvatīputra, furthermore, when those bodhisattva great beings are approaching the time of death and are passing away from that buddhafield, signs such as these will appear. In all the world systems of the ten directions, in some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings being born among the gods of Tuṣita. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings dwelling among the gods of Tuṣita. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings passing away from among the gods of Tuṣita. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings entering their mother's womb. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings being born from their mother's womb. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings taking seven steps. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings laughing a great laugh. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings displaying the play of youth. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings dwelling amid a retinue of queens. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings going forth from home into homelessness. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings showing their engagement in austerities. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings going to the seat of awakening. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings examining the seat of awakening.

In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings circumambulating the seat of awakening with reverence and respect. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings undertaking to sit at the seat of awakening. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings seated at the seat of awakening. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings subduing Māra the Evil One. In some world systems they see bodhisattva great beings fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening and attaining the wisdom of omniscience. In some world systems they see buddhas, blessed ones, turning the wheel of Dharma. In some world systems they see buddhas, blessed ones, giving prophecies to bodhisattva great beings. In some world systems they see buddhas, blessed ones, passing into complete nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates. Śāradvatīputra, when those bodhisattva great beings are approaching the time of death and are passing away from that buddhafield, such signs as these will appear.

Śāradvatīputra, the lifespan of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, lasts for a million great eons. Śāradvatīputra, even after that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, has passed into complete nirvāṇa through the great complete nirvāṇa, the sublime Dharma spoken by the Sugata will remain for a million great eons.

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, how are those million great eons during which the sublime Dharma spoken by the Sugata will remain to be counted?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, twenty intermediate eons make one eon, and ten eons make one great eon. Śāradvatīputra, for a million great eons counted in this way, the sublime Dharma spoken by the Sugata will remain."

Śāradvatīputra, when his sacred Dharma comes to disappear, a great light will appear throughout that entire great trichiliocosm world system. The great earth will also quake, and a great sound will also resound.

Śāradvatīputra, the sacred Dharma of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya will not be made to disappear by Māra or by the gods of Māra's host. Nor will his sacred Dharma be made to disappear by the Blessed One's śrāvakas. Rather, Śāradvatīputra, the people there will come to have little desire to hear the sacred Dharma. Because their

desire is slight, they will not go into the presence of the monks who preach the Dharma. Because they do not go there, they will not hear the sacred Dharma. Because they have not heard the sacred Dharma, they will not put it into practice. Because they do not practice, they will not attain the higher distinctions. And the monks who preach the Dharma, knowing that those people have little desire, will not teach the Dharma either. Śāradvatīputra, it is by such a sequence that his sacred Dharma will disappear.

This concludes the fifth chapter of The Array of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya.

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said this to the Blessed One: "Venerable Blessed One, with what kind of roots of virtue, and by what cause and what condition, will bodhisattva great beings be born in that buddhafield?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Śāradvatīputra, here, if a bodhisattva great being generates the resolve and makes the aspiration thus: 'Whatever practices the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya engaged in formerly, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, I shall practice those practices and I shall accomplish those practices,' then he will be born in the buddhafield, the world called Abhirati, in the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, that is the cause, and that is the condition, by which a bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being should dedicate the perfection of generosity to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, thinking, 'Through possessing this root of virtue, may I keep company with the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.' Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause by which a bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield, and that too is a condition.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being should dedicate the perfection of moral discipline to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, thinking, 'Through possessing this root of virtue, may I keep company with the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.' Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause by which a bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield, and that too is a condition.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being should dedicate the perfection of patience to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, thinking, 'Through possessing this root of virtue, may I keep company with the

Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.' Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause by which a bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield, and that too is a condition.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being should dedicate the perfection of diligence to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, thinking, 'Through possessing this root of virtue, may I keep company with the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.' Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause by which a bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield, and that too is a condition.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being should dedicate the perfection of meditative concentration to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, thinking, 'Through possessing this root of virtue, may I keep company with the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.' Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause by which a bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield, and that too is a condition.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being should dedicate the perfection of wisdom to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, thinking, 'Through possessing this root of virtue, may I keep company with the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya.' Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause by which a bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield, and that too is a condition.

Furthermore, one should recollect in detail the Dharma taught by that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya. One should also recollect in detail the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, a Saṅgha that is measureless, countless, inexpressible, and more inexpressible than the inexpressible. One should also recollect in detail the bodhisattvas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who far exceed all counting. One should recollect them in detail with this thought: "Just so, I too, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, shall teach the Dharma, and in the buddhafield where I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, the Saṅgha of śrāvakas and the assembly of bodhisattvas will be measureless, countless, inexpressible, and more inexpressible than the inexpressible."

Śāradvatīputra, a son of noble family who possesses these three aspects should train properly in this way, thinking: "I shall make this root of virtue endowed with three aspects shared in common with all sentient beings, and having made it shared in common with all sentient beings, I shall dedicate it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening." Thus one should dedicate the root of virtue endowed with three aspects for the sake of all sentient beings.

Śāradvatīputra, because for a bodhisattva, a great being, who has dedicated in three aspects there is no falling away in the interval, Śāradvatīputra, if even through a root of virtue endowed with three aspects the bodhisattva, the great being, fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and is also born in that buddhafield, what need is there to mention that through a root of virtue endowed with all the perfections he will be born in the presence of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya? Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause for the bodhisattva, the great being, to be born in that buddhafield. That too is a condition.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to be born in that buddhafield should see the great trichiliocosm, the world system, illuminated in its entirety by the light of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Having seen this, he should generate a mind that recollects in detail, thinking: "In the buddhafield where I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, I too shall illuminate it with my own light." Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause for the bodhisattva, the great being, to be born in that buddhafield. That too is a condition.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to be born in that buddhafield should generate the mind in this way, thinking: "While I practice the conduct of a bodhisattva, I shall see the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, measureless, countless, inexpressible, and more inexpressible than the inexpressible. Having seen them, I shall act in such a way and strive in such a way that in the buddhafield where I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening there will also arise a Saṅgha of śrāvakas that is measureless, countless, inexpressible, and more inexpressible than the inexpressible." Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause for the bodhisattva, the great being, to be born in that buddhafield. That too is a condition.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to be born in that buddhafield should generate the mind in this way, thinking: "While I practice the conduct of a bodhisattva, I shall see the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, endowed with the supreme of all qualities. Having seen it, I shall act in such a way and strive in such a way that the buddhafield where I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening will likewise be endowed with the supreme of all qualities." Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause for the bodhisattva, the great being, to be born in that buddhafield. That too is a condition.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, there are bodhisattvas, great beings, who are reckoned among the tathāgatas, reckoned among the buddhas, and reckoned among the omniscient: the bodhisattva, the great being Gandhahastin, Bullock Gandhahastin, and other such measureless, countless bodhisattvas, great beings. If a son or daughter of noble family, merely by hearing their names, makes an aspiration toward that buddhafield and is born there, what need is there to mention that, by dedicating roots of virtue endowed with all the perfections toward wherever that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya dwells, one will without fail be born in that buddhafield? Śāradvatīputra, that too is a cause for the bodhisattva, the great being, to be born in that buddhafield. That too is a condition.

Śāradvatīputra, the extent of the root of virtue of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening cannot be grasped. Śāradvatīputra, even if all sentient beings were to fill vessels as vast as space and carry them away, scooping it out with such great vessels could not exhaust that root of virtue.

Śāradvatīputra, the root of virtue of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening cannot be measured by vessels. Śāradvatīputra, its vessel is omniscience itself. Śāradvatīputra, from a root of virtue endowed with three aspects one comes to obtain the lineage of the Three Jewels. Śāradvatīputra, all those bodhisattva great beings who possess this root of virtue dedicated in three aspects should be regarded as of a nature never to fall into the lower states. Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great being who possesses a root of virtue dedicated in three aspects subdues Māra the Evil One and the gods of Māra's realm, and in whatever buddhafield he wishes to be born, in that very buddhafield he will be born.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to be born in that buddhafield should recollect, by way of their aspects, the buddhas, the blessed ones, who dwell in the immeasurable, countless world systems of the eastern direction. He should also recollect, by way of its aspects, the Dharma those buddhas, those blessed ones, have taught. He should also recollect, by way of their aspects, all the Saṅghas of śrāvakas and the assemblies of bodhisattvas of those buddhas, those blessed ones. That root of virtue endowed with three aspects should then be dedicated toward the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, wherever he may be. Śāradvatīputra, that is the cause by which the bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield. That is also the condition.

Likewise he should recollect, by way of their aspects, all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who dwell in all the buddhafields of the southern, western and northern directions, likewise of the nadir and the zenith, and likewise of all the ten directions. He should also recollect, by way of their aspects, all the teachings those buddhas, those blessed ones, have taught. He should also recollect, by way of their aspects, all the Saṅghas of śrāvakas and the assemblies of bodhisattvas of those buddhas, those blessed ones. Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great being should rejoice in those roots of virtue endowed with three aspects, and having rejoiced, he should dedicate them toward the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya, wherever he may be. When they are dedicated there, his birth in that buddhafield will not fail.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, in many buddhafields, in many hundreds of buddhafields, in many thousands of buddhafields, in many hundreds of thousands of buddhafields, and even in many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of buddhafields, there are no such beautiful arrays of qualities as those of this present buddhafield. Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva great being should generate the resolve thus: "By this root of virtue of mine, may I see arrays of buddhafield qualities like the beautiful array of qualities of the present buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya. Having seen such arrays of buddhafield qualities, I shall take up such arrays of buddhafield qualities. Having taken them up, through the instruction of my guides, the blessed ones, the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas such as Akṣobhya, I shall rightly teach many hundreds of

bodhisattvas, many thousands of bodhisattvas, many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas, and many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of bodhisattvas about unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening; I shall cause them rightly to take it up; I shall rightly inspire them; and I shall rightly make them rejoice." Śāradvatīputra, that is the cause by which the bodhisattva great being will be born in that buddhafield. That is also the condition.

Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to secure birth in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya should generate the resolve in this way with superior intention. If he does not do so, he will be deceiving that very Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, those bodhisattvas who generate the resolve in this way with superior intention will be born in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, I prophesy that any son or daughter of good family who generates the resolve in this way with superior intention will be born in the buddhafield of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Akṣobhya.

The fifth fascicle.

Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was formerly practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he made this great aspiration: "Oh! When those beings who wish to be born in the buddhafield where I shall have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening come to the time of their death, may I too, surrounded by the Saṅgha of śrāvakas and preceded by the assembly of bodhisattvas, be present before them. And may they, seeing me, become deeply joyful in mind, and with unimpaired mindfulness and an undistracted mind pass away and be born in my buddhafield."

Because he made that great aspiration, Śāradvatīputra, any son or daughter of good family who hears the name of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who, having heard it, keeps it in mind, and who sets about depicting the form of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya seated on a lotus seat upon an elephant throne, will be blessed in this way. When that son or daughter of good family comes to the time of death, the

Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya will come, surrounded by the Saṅgha of śrāvakas and preceded by the assembly of bodhisattvas, and that person will see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya present before them. Having seen him, their mind will be joyful, and without forgetfulness and with an undistracted mind they will pass away. Having passed away, they will be born in that very buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the world-system Abhirati.

When that son or daughter of good family practices the Dharma of giving, then at the time of death they will see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Having seen him, they will have all their misdeeds cleared away and will be born in that buddhafield.

Śāradvatīputra, when the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was formerly practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he made an aspiration such as this: "Oh! When those beings who wish to be born in the buddhafield where I shall have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening come to the time of their death, may I be present before them, surrounded by the Saṅgha of śrāvakas and attended in front by the assembly of bodhisattvas. And may they, seeing me, have faith in their minds, and, without forgetfulness and with an undistracted mind, pass away and be born in my buddhafield."

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose, for example, there were a city without parks and pleasure groves, without the enjoyment of streams, ponds, rivers and pools, and without horses or elephants, but full of sand, gravel, stones and potsherds, thick with thorns, and hard to travel through. Śāradvatīputra, even if a mighty king possessed of an army were to dwell in that city, Śāradvatīputra, that city would not be beautiful, because it lacks those qualities of a city. Śāradvatīputra, in this way, even granted that the king is mighty and possessed of an army, that city is not beautiful, because it lacks the qualities of a city.

Śāradvatīputra, just as that king is mighty and possessed of an army, so, Śāradvatīputra, in this great trichiliocosm world-system the Tathāgata is a Dharma king possessed of an army. Yet, Śāradvatīputra, this buddhafield of mine is not beautiful, because it lacks such arrays of qualities as belong to the buddhafield of Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, if such arrays of buddhafield qualities were to arise in this buddhafield of mine as well, then this

buddhafield of mine too would become beautiful, just as the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya is beautiful now.

Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to purify and wishes to take up an array of buddhafield qualities should purify it and take it up in just the way that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya purified and took up an array of buddhafield qualities when he was formerly practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, now that I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, there are the beings whom I have established in the fruit of stream-entry, established in the fruit of once-returning, established in the fruit of non-returning, established in arhatship, and established in solitary awakening. And, Śāradvatīputra, there are all the śrāvakas among the other beings whom my śrāvakas have trained. Yet even if all of these were gathered together, compared with the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, those Saṅghas of śrāvakas would not come near even a hundredth part of it. They do not bear comparison with a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a hundred-millionth part, a part in ten thousand million, a part in a million million, or a part in a hundred thousand million niyutas. They do not bear comparison in number, in fraction, in counting, in analogy, or in cause. Why is that? Because that Saṅgha is immeasurable and countless; but it is not in respect of liberation.

Śāradvatīputra, leave aside my own śrāvakas. Śāradvatīputra, suppose one gathered together all the śrāvakas who will appear in the future under the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Maitreya, and all the śrāvakas who will be those that these śrāvakas train from among other beings. Even then, they would not come close to a hundredth part of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Nor would they come close to a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a part in a hundred koṭis, a part in a thousand koṭis, a part in a hundred thousand koṭis, or a part in a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas. They do not bear comparison in number, in fraction, in counting, in simile, or in cause. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, no one at all can grasp the measure of the beings who are trained by each single teaching of the Dharma given by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

Śāradvatīputra, leave aside my own śrāvakas. Leave aside, too, the śrāvakas of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Maitreya. Śāradvatīputra, suppose one gathered together all the śrāvakas who will appear in the future under all the buddhas, the blessed ones, of the Fortunate Eon, and all the śrāvakas who will be those other śrāvakas that these śrāvakas train. Even then, they would not come close to a hundredth part of the śrāvakas of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Nor would they come close to a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a part in a hundred koṭis, a part in a thousand koṭis, a part in a hundred thousand koṭis, or a part in a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas. They do not bear comparison in number, in fraction, in counting, in simile, or in cause. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, the measure of the beings who are trained by each single teaching of the Dharma given by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya cannot be grasped. Yet it is not with respect to liberation that they differ.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said this to the Blessed One: "Venerable Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has said, Venerable Blessed One, that buddhafield should be regarded not as a field of ordinary beings but as a field of arhats. Why is that? Because, Venerable Blessed One, there are many arhats there whose defilements are exhausted."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Śāradvatīputra, so it is. Śāradvatīputra, it is just as you have said: there are many arhats there whose defilements are exhausted. Śāradvatīputra, one could grasp the measure of all the stars in this great trichiliocosm, but one cannot grasp the measure of the beings in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya who attain arhatship through each single teaching of the Dharma given by that Tathāgata. Śāradvatīputra, it should be understood in this way: at each great assembly, immeasurable and countless beings attain arhatship. Śāradvatīputra, one could grasp the measure of all the stars in this great trichiliocosm, but in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the measure of the great assemblies that gather there cannot be grasped.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, those gods and humans are free from busyness as they cultivate roots of virtue. And Śāradvatīputra, the sons or daughters of good family who are born in that great trichiliocosm are also free from busyness day and night.

"Śāradvatīputra, as for those who listen to this Dharma discourse praising his qualities, and who, having heard it, have faith in it, take it up, keep it, read it, master it, and teach it extensively and correctly to others as well, this is because all of them come to see and hear the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya as he formerly practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva. Why is that? Because they will hear this Dharma discourse praising his qualities, and, having heard it, the very moment they hear it they will gain great faith.

"Śāradvatīputra, this Dharma discourse praising the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya has been spoken by the buddhas, the blessed ones, in all the buddhafields of all the ten directions; it is spoken, and it will be spoken. Śāradvatīputra, the sons or daughters of good family who dwell in those buddhafields will also take up this Dharma discourse praising his qualities, will keep it, will read it, will master it, and will teach it extensively and correctly to others as well. Śāradvatīputra, in those world systems, apart from the irreversible bodhisattva great beings who will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening in those very buddhafields, the other sons or daughters of good family, whether of the bodhisattva vehicle or of the śrāvaka vehicle, for the most part, by the power of their aspirations, have been born, are being born, or will be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya."

Śāradvatīputra, in this way the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya dwells in the world realm Abhirati, and yet he benefits the persons of the bodhisattva vehicle and the persons of the śrāvaka vehicle in all the buddhafields of the ten directions.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. When the seven precious things have appeared for a wheel-turning king (cakravartin), he holds sway over the four great continents by means of those seven precious things. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, through this Dharma discourse proclaiming his qualities, holds sway over the sons or daughters of good family of the bodhisattva

vehicle in all the buddhafields of the ten directions, and he holds sway over his own buddhafield as well.

Śāradvatīputra, there may be sons or daughters of good family who listen to this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and who, having heard it, retain it, keep it, read it, master it, teach it correctly and at length to others, and also make the aspiration to be born in that buddhafield. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya will always keep them in mind, right up until the end of their lives. And why is that? Śāradvatīputra, it is so that Māra the Evil One will find no opening to harm them, and so that beings under the sway of māras will not turn back their aspirations. Śāradvatīputra, it should be understood that those sons or daughters of good family whom the Tathāgata keeps in mind are in no danger of turning back from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, or from birth in that buddhafield.

Moreover, whatever else strives to cut short their lives, and whatever may become a danger to their lives, such as fire, water, poison and weapons, will not strike the bodies of those sons and daughters of good family. Nor will other things, such as blows of the hand, clods of earth or staffs, strike their bodies. It should also be understood that they have no fear of humans or nonhumans. Thus it should be understood that they are guarded, protected and sheltered on every side. And when the time comes for them to die, they will be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, in the world realm called Abhirati.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. The disk of the sun, though it stands far away, gives light to the people of Jambudvīpa. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, though he dwells far away, gives the light of wisdom to the sons and daughters of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle who live in other world realms.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. A monk who has the divine eye, though he stays far away, sees forms of fine color and of poor color. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, though he dwells far away, sees the colors, shapes and forms of the bodhisattva great beings who live in other world realms.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. A monk who has miraculous powers and has gone to the far shore of supreme mastery of mind, though he stays far away, knows correctly the minds of humans and nonhumans. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, though he dwells far away, knows correctly the minds of the bodhisattva great beings who live in other world realms.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. A monk who has miraculous powers, though he stays far away, hears sounds with his ear. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, though he dwells far away, hears the bodhisattva great beings who live in other world realms saying, "We too shall be born in that buddhafield, the world realm Abhirati." And, Śāradvatīputra, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya also knows the names and clans of those sons and daughters of good family.

Śāradvatīputra, those who retain this Dharma discourse proclaiming his qualities, who keep it, read it, master it, and teach it correctly and at length to others, are seen by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. They are known by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Right up until the time of their death, they will be kept in mind by the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya.

When he had said this, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, how wondrous it is, Blessed One, how fully the buddhas, the blessed ones, embrace the bodhisattva great beings! Sugata, it is truly wondrous!"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is; so it is."

It is just as you have said: the buddhas, the blessed ones, thoroughly safeguard the bodhisattva great beings. Why is that? Śāradvatīputra, because they thoroughly safeguard the bodhisattva great beings, all sentient beings too come to be thoroughly safeguarded.

Śāradvatīputra, it is like this. Suppose a king, a kṣatriya consecrated on the crown of his head, possessed one, two, three, four, five, ten, twenty, thirty, forty, fifty, a hundred, a thousand, a hundred thousand, or a great many storehouses filled with śāli rice, grain, barley, wheat, sesame, peas, chickpeas, lentils, or any other kind of grain. He would think, "When famine comes, or

when there is want, these will make it a good year," and so he would thoroughly safeguard them. Why is that? Because when famine comes, they will be the sustenance of sentient beings.

Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, when the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, have passed away, the bodhisattva great beings will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Having fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, they teach the true Dharma to all the sentient beings who are starved of the true Dharma, and so there comes to be a good year of the true Dharma and a good year of the Saṅgha. Śāradvatīputra, for this reason the buddhas, the blessed ones, thoroughly safeguard the bodhisattva great beings.

Śāradvatīputra, there are bodhisattva great beings who listen to this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and who, having heard it, retain it, keep it, read it, and master it, and also teach it extensively and correctly to others. They lead many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of living beings to take up this Dharma discourse correctly; they introduce them to it and establish them in it, and they also make aspirations to be born in that buddhafield. All of them will be born in that buddhafield.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, there are bodhisattva great beings who listen to this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and who, having heard it, retain it, keep it, read it, and master it, and also teach it extensively and correctly to others. If they lead many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of living beings to take up this Dharma discourse correctly, introducing them to it and establishing them in it, then even if they have not made aspirations to be born in that buddhafield, those bodhisattva great beings should be known to be irreversible, and should be known to have been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. They will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, each in their own buddhafield.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, there are bodhisattva great beings who listen to this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and who, having heard it, retain it, keep it, read it, and master it, and also teach it extensively and correctly to others. Having retained it, kept it, read it, and mastered it, and having taught it extensively and correctly to others, they lead many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of living beings to take up this Dharma discourse correctly; they introduce them to it and establish them in it. If many hundreds of thousands of living beings then generate roots of virtue, the more roots of virtue those sentient beings generate, the closer those bodhisattvas come to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening should retain this Dharma discourse proclaiming these qualities, should keep it, should read it, and should master it. Having retained it, kept it, read it, and mastered it, he should explain it to many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of living beings, and should teach it to them correctly. Why is that? Śāradvatīputra, because the more a bodhisattva great being teaches this Dharma discourse, the more he accumulates karma that leads to great wisdom; and through having performed and accumulated that karma leading to great wisdom, they will attain the exhaustion of the defilements in that very body.

Śāradvatīputra, there are sons or daughters of good family belonging to the Śrāvaka Vehicle who listen to this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Having heard it, they take it up, keep it, read it, and master it, and they also teach it extensively and correctly to others. They also lead and bring many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of living beings to take up this Dharma discourse correctly, and they establish them in it. All of them will realize arhatship directly in that very body. Śāradvatīputra, even if they do not realize arhatship directly in that very body, they will not pass beyond the time of a second perfectly complete buddha.

Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, sons or daughters of good family of the Śrāvaka Vehicle who wish to realize arhatship directly in that very body should listen to this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Having heard it, they should take it up, keep it, read it, and master it, and they should teach it extensively and correctly to others. They should also lead many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of living beings to take up this Dharma discourse correctly. They should bring them to it, and they should establish them in it.

Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, sons or daughters of good family who uphold the sublime Dharma in this way will realize arhatship directly in that very body. Śāradvatīputra, any sons or daughters of good family who teach this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities to others correctly and at the proper time will realize arhatship directly in that very body. They will not pass beyond the appearance of a second buddha.

Śāradvatīputra, to the extent that those sons or daughters of good family of the Śrāvaka Vehicle take up, keep, read, and master this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and teach it extensively and correctly to others, to that same extent they will perform and accumulate actions that lead to great wisdom. Through the actions leading to great wisdom that they have performed and accumulated, they will realize arhatship directly in that very body. Śāradvatīputra, even if they do not realize arhatship directly in that very body, they will not pass beyond the time of a second perfectly complete buddha.

Śāradvatīputra, seeing this compelling reason, sons and daughters of good family of the Śrāvaka Vehicle should hold this Dharma discourse in reverence and apply themselves to it. Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, sons or daughters of good family of the Śrāvaka Vehicle who wish to uphold the sublime Dharma should take up, keep, read, and master this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and they should teach it extensively and correctly to others.

Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, there are sons or daughters of good family of the Śrāvaka Vehicle who listen to this Dharma discourse that proclaims the

qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Having heard it, they take it up, keep it, read it, and master it, and they also teach it extensively and correctly to others. They also lead and bring many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of living beings to take up this Dharma discourse correctly, and they establish them in it. If they then practice it as yoga in accordance with suchness, exert themselves, strive, train, and have faith in it, then, Śāradvatīputra, it should be understood that those sons or daughters of good family of the Śrāvaka Vehicle are abiding in their final existence, or are bound to one more birth, or are bound to two more births. They will not pass beyond the time of a second perfectly complete buddha.

Śāradvatīputra, beings of little merit are unable to hear this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Śāradvatīputra, if through the power of the Buddha it should reach the ears of any son or daughter of good family whatsoever, that son or daughter of good family should very quickly take it up, keep it, read it, and master it, and should teach it extensively and correctly to others.

Śāradvatīputra, suppose some son or daughter of good family, for the sake of certain beings, were to fill this Jambudvīpa with treasure and gold and give it away as a gift, wholly relinquishing it, with the thought, "Oh, may this being hear this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya!" Even so, Śāradvatīputra, beings of little merit would be unable to hear this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, this Dharma discourse thoroughly discerns all phenomena and leads faithful sons and daughters of good family to a completely pure buddha field.

Śāradvatīputra, this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya will not remain in the hands of those whose wisdom is corrupt. Rather, Śāradvatīputra, this Dharma discourse will remain in the hands of the learned, those endowed with profound wisdom. Śāradvatīputra, those sons or daughters of noble family in whose hands this Dharma discourse remains, and on whose person it is kept, see the Tathāgata.

Śāradvatīputra, suppose, for example, that some priceless, precious jewel of great value were brought out from the great ocean. Śāradvatīputra, what do you think? Into whose hands would that precious jewel come first?

He replied, "Venerable Blessed One, that jewel would come first into the hands of kings, or princes, or the great ministers of kings."

The Blessed One said, "Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya will remain in the hands of bodhisattvas. Śāradvatīputra, those bodhisattva great beings who listen to this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and having heard it, take it up, keep it, read it, master it, teach it extensively and correctly to others as well, and practice it as the genuine yoga for unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, will become irreversible."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, since that is so, sons or daughters of noble family who wish to abide on the irreversible ground should take up this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, keep it, read it, master it, and teach it extensively and correctly to others as well. And why is that? Venerable Blessed One, it is because when bodhisattva great beings enter into this Dharma discourse, they will attain the nature of irreversibility."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāradvatīputra: "Śāradvatīputra, so it is; so it is. It is just as you have said. Sons or daughters of noble family who wish to abide on the irreversible ground should take up this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, keep it, read it, master it, and teach it extensively and correctly to others as well.

"Śāradvatīputra, for example, the seven precious possessions of a wheel-turning monarch arise from the maturation of his karma. Śāradvatīputra, in the same way, my explaining this Dharma discourse that proclaims his qualities to the fourfold assembly, and teaching it extensively and correctly, is likewise explained and extensively and correctly taught through the past aspiration of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who has fully and perfectly awakened

to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. All those bodhisattva great beings who have heard, and who will listen to, this Dharma discourse that proclaims his qualities, hear it and listen to it through the special power of the aspirations that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya made in the past while engaging in the conduct of a bodhisattva, and through the maturation of their own roots of virtue.

"Śāradvatīputra, all those blessed buddhas, the nine hundred and ninety-six buddhas who will appear in this Fortunate Eon, will also explain to the fourfold assembly this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and teach it extensively and correctly, with nothing added and nothing omitted, just as I am now explaining it to the fourfold assembly and teaching it extensively and correctly.

"Therefore, Śāradvatīputra, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to awaken swiftly and fully to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening should take up this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha Akṣobhya, keep it, read it, master it, and teach it extensively and correctly to others as well."

Śāradvatīputra, suppose some person of the bodhisattva vehicle who has gone forth from the household life cannot find a way to hear, take up, retain, recite, master, and teach extensively to others this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. And suppose, Śāradvatīputra, that someone says to that person of the bodhisattva vehicle who has gone forth from the household life: "Son of good family, if you will live in a household and take your pleasure among a retinue of wives, then I will give you this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya." Then, Śāradvatīputra, out of respect for this Dharma discourse, if that person of the bodhisattva vehicle who has gone forth from the household life can in this way find the chance to hear, take up, retain, recite, master, or teach extensively to others this Dharma discourse, he should go to the household, enter among the retinue of wives, take up this Dharma discourse and master it, and then go forth once again. I permit it, and declare that there is no transgression for that person of the bodhisattva vehicle who had gone forth from the household life and went among the retinue of wives. And why is that? Because, Śāradvatīputra, even when that person of the bodhisattva vehicle passes away, this Dharma discourse that

praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya will not disappear.

Śāradvatīputra, if in any village, any town, or any place far away, this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya is in active use, that bodhisattva, that great being, should travel even there, and having arrived there, he should take up, retain, recite, and master this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and teach it extensively to others.

Śāradvatīputra, suppose some son or daughter of good family has given rise to the thought, "I shall take up, retain, recite, and master this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and teach it extensively to others." And suppose, Śāradvatīputra, that another son or daughter of good family, though unable to recite this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, has it in hand in the form of a book. Then the first should borrow that book, thinking, "I will take it back with me and copy the book myself." And if the owner will not lend the book, he should copy it right there.

Śāradvatīputra, if that son or daughter of good family says, "Son of good family, if you dare to copy it while fasting, then I will give you this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya," then he should stay fasting and copy it. If he says, "Copy it while walking," then he should copy it while walking. If he says, "Copy it standing," then he should copy it standing. If he says, "Copy it sitting," then he should copy it sitting.

Śāradvatīputra, if some bodhisattva, some great being, goes to a village or a town for the sake of this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and does not find this Dharma discourse there, then he should travel on to other kingdoms or other lands, and go wherever he may hear of it. And having arrived there, he should hear, take up, retain, recite, and master this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and teach it extensively to others.

Śāradvatīputra, if, having thus gone to the place where he heard of it, he still does not find it, he should give rise to this thought: "Since I have heard the very name of that Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, I have no fear of turning back from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. And the one who has now made known to me the name of that Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya wishes me benefit, wishes me happiness, wishes me welfare, and wishes me success and ease."

Śāradvatīputra, I have spoken this Dharma discourse that praises the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya through the power of the former aspirations of that very Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. And that any sons or daughters of good family have heard it, or will hear it, is due to the might of the Buddha and to the ripening of their own roots of virtue.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, after the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, has passed away, by whose power will this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya be heard?"

The Blessed One said, "Śāradvatīputra, after I have passed away, this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya will be heard through the power of that very Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. As the preachers of the true Dharma speak this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, so too the Four Great Kings and Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, will be filled with enthusiasm. And through the karmic maturation of those bodhisattva great beings who will listen to it, the Four Great Kings and Śakra, lord of the gods, will also be filled with enthusiasm."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, this Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya is endowed with great and excellent qualities."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is, so it is. It is just as you have said. This Dharma discourse proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya is endowed with great and excellent qualities.

"Śāradvatīputra, if any sons or daughters of good family, having become afraid or terrified, recite the name of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, the fear and terror of those sons or daughters of good family will vanish.

"Śāradvatīputra, if in some region a hailstorm like fierce wheels should fall, then while it is falling, sons and daughters of good family should recite the name of that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and say: 'Formerly, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, through truth and words of truth he freed many hundreds of nāgas, many thousands of nāgas, many hundreds of thousands of nāgas, many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of nāgas who were suffering. And having freed them, he dedicated those roots of virtue thus: "By this root of virtue, once I have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, whenever in other world systems, one after another, wrathful nāgas send down hailstorms like fierce wheels, may whatever beings there are afraid and terrified recite my name, and there, through my power, may those hailstorms like fierce wheels be pacified." By that truth and word of truth of his dedication, may these hailstorms like fierce wheels falling upon us be pacified!' Merely by saying this, those hailstorms of the nāgas, like fierce wheels, will be pacified, Śāradvatīputra, except for the maturation of those beings' past karma.

"Furthermore, Śāradvatīputra, when fear, terror, epidemic disease, or harm befalls sons or daughters of good family, they should recollect that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and say: 'Formerly, when that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he made vows and spoke words with truth and words of truth, and all those vows and spoken words have been completely fulfilled. By that truth and word of truth, which has reached the far shore of all those vows and spoken words, may these fears, terrors, epidemic diseases, and harms subside!' Merely by saying this, those fears, those terrors, those epidemic diseases, and those

harms will subside, Śāradvatīputra, except for the maturation of those beings' past karma."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Blessed One, it is one bodhisattva great being who fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, not two. Since that is so, venerable Blessed One, a bodhisattva great being who wishes to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening should fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening just as the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāradvatīputra, "Śāradvatīputra, so it is, so it is. It is just as you have said. A bodhisattva great being who wishes to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening should fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening just as the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Śāradvatīputra, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya purified a buddhafield and took up a buddhafield in a certain way. Few are the bodhisattva great beings who purify a buddhafield in that way and who take up a buddhafield in that way.

Śāradvatīputra, when all those bodhisattva great beings fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, the buddhahood of those buddhas, the blessed ones, is the same. Their omniscience is the same. Their color is the same. Their marks are the same. Their family is the same. They are the same in taking up a buddhafield. Their gatherings of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas are the same. Their liberation is the same. Beyond that, the only differences are that the array of qualities of the buddhas' buddhafields differs, their lion thrones differ, and their lotus maṇḍalas differ.

Then the gods who dwell in the desire realm and the Brahmakāyika gods bowed with joined palms toward the east, where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was. They paid homage and said, "The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni has taught here this Dharma discourse that proclaims the qualities of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, who dwells in another world. Homage to

that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya! Homage to that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya! Homage!" Three times they uttered this exclamation.

Then those gods of the desire realm and those Brahmakāyika gods scattered divine mandārava flowers, great mandārava flowers, and divine incense over the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni. They scattered them, scattered them abundantly, and scattered them most abundantly. As soon as they had scattered them, through the power of the Buddha those flowers and that incense remained in the sky above the Blessed One as a great canopy of flowers. Moreover, in order to make offerings to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, those gods of the desire realm and those Brahmakāyika gods scattered flowers toward where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought, "I shall request the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha that, through the power of the Buddha, the fourfold assembly, these gods of the desire realm, and these Brahmakāyika gods may see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya."

Then the Blessed One, knowing in his mind the thought in the mind of Śakra, lord of the gods, rose up into the sky by miraculous power and sat cross-legged in the air. Through the power of the Buddha, the fourfold assembly too rose up into the sky above and remained in the air. Through the power of the Buddha, those gods of the desire realm and those Brahmakāyika gods too rose up into the sky above and remained in the air.

Then the Blessed One at that time performed a display of miraculous power such as this. Because he performed such a display of miraculous power, the fourfold assembly, those gods of the desire realm, Śakra, lord of the gods, and those Brahmakāyika gods saw the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya together with his Saṅgha of śrāvakas and surrounded by his host of bodhisattvas, and they also saw that buddhafield. Having seen this, all of them placed their right knees on the air above, bowed with joined palms toward where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya was, and paid homage to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete

Buddha Akṣobhya.

Then the fourfold assembly saw the people of the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, and they thought, "These beings who possess the color, the features, and the form of gods: are they gods of the Thirty-Three who have come from the abode of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three in order to behold the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya, to pay homage to him, to attend upon him, and to listen to the Dharma? Or are they not?"

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought, "These are gods who, in order to listen to the true Dharma, have taken on the guise and signs of human beings and are sitting in the presence of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Why is that? Because never before have I seen or heard of such beauty, splendor, and excellent good fortune among human beings."

Then the Blessed One withdrew those miraculous displays.

Then the Blessed One understood that those four assemblies, and those gods of the desire realm and the form realm, still had doubts and were in two minds. He said to Śakra, lord of the gods, "Kauśika (that is, Śakra), the human beings who are born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya possess the comforts and the enjoyments of the gods."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought, "Those human beings who both see the Buddha and possess the enjoyments and comforts of the gods are endowed with the excellence of the gods, and that is a state to be desired. Those human beings who pass away from other world systems and other buddhafields and come to be born in the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya are also to be envied."

Then the venerable Śāradvatīputra said to Śakra, lord of the gods, "Kauśika, you see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, and you also see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Akṣobhya. Kauśika, if by that alone your body has gained what is truly worth gaining, then, Kauśika, what need is there even to speak of the gain you would have if you were born in that buddhafield?"

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought, "If even those in whose ears this Dharma discourse proclaiming those qualities resounds have gained what is truly worth gaining, what need is there even to speak of those who come to be born in that buddhafield?"

Then the Blessed One said to Śakra, lord of the gods, "Kauśika, those persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who come to be born in that buddhafield have gained what is truly worth gaining. Why is that? Kauśika, it is because they will abide in the state of irreversibility. Kauśika, whatever living beings set their minds on being born in that buddhafield, from the very moment they set their minds on it they should be regarded as irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings."

When the Blessed One taught this Dharma discourse, the minds of about five thousand monks were freed from the defilements without clinging. Eight thousand monks of the bodhisattva vehicle made the aspiration to be born in that buddhafield. Five thousand nuns of the bodhisattva vehicle also made the aspiration to be born in that buddhafield. A hundred thousand laymen of the bodhisattva vehicle also made the aspiration to be born in that buddhafield. Ten thousand laywomen of the bodhisattva vehicle also made the aspiration to be born in that buddhafield. Very many thousands of gods of the desire realm also made the aspiration to be born in that buddhafield, and the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha prophesied of all of them that they would be born in that buddhafield and would fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Whatever other beings make the aspiration to be born in that buddhafield, they too will receive there the prophecy that they will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, and having received the prophecy, they will be born in that very buddhafield.

Moreover, when the Blessed One taught this Dharma discourse, through the power and the blessing of this Dharma discourse this entire great trichiliocosm, this great world system of a billion worlds, shook in six ways. It moved, moved strongly, and moved strongly everywhere. It stirred, stirred strongly, and stirred strongly everywhere. It quaked, quaked strongly, and quaked strongly everywhere. It was shaken, shaken strongly, and shaken strongly everywhere. It roared, roared strongly, and roared strongly everywhere. It resounded, resounded strongly, and resounded strongly everywhere. And the world was pervaded by a great light.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Śāradvatīputra, the venerable Ānanda, the Four Great Kings, Śakra, lord of the gods, Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, those monks, that whole assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the sixth chapter, called the Array of Akṣobhya, from the Dharma discourse of a hundred thousand chapters, the Noble Great Heap of Jewels.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Surendrabodhi and the chief editor and translator, the monk Yeshé Dé.

Translator's Notes

• The name of the tathāgata in Abhirati, □□□□□□□□□□□, is translated literally as "Great Eye" because its Sanskrit form cannot be identified with confidence; Mahānetra, Mahācakṣus and Viśālākṣa have all been proposed, and the Chinese parallel reads "Great Eye."
• The word rendered "unperturbed" in Great Eye's reply is the same word as the name Akṣobhya, "the Unperturbed." The sūtra thus points ahead to the monk's later name. The oath formula "then let it be that I have deceived" renders a wish form. Its sense is a self-imposed condition: should he fail, he would have broken faith with all present buddhas.
• The recurring oath formula, literally "may those buddhas have been deceived by me," is a self-imprecation: should the vow be broken, the speaker would stand as one who has deceived all the buddhas. The list of ascetic practices corresponds to the dhutaguṇas. A few items are rendered by their usual Sanskrit equivalents: "remaining sitting" for naiṣadika, "accepting whatever seat is given" for yāthāsaṃstarika, and "garments of felt" for nāmatika. "Accept whatever food is obtained" for □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is somewhat uncertain. The piece ends in mid-sentence.
• The refrain "may I have deceived those buddhas" renders the self-imprecatory oath form of the vow: should the bodhisattva fail in the stated resolve, he would thereby have deceived all the buddhas. "Speaking otherwise than that" renders a terse phrase, probably meaning speech contrary to the truth or idle speech; its exact sense is uncertain. In the vow about the saffron-robed, the phrase rendered "it making no difference" (literally "there is not") is elliptical; the sense seems to be that the bodhisattva makes no distinction between monks who are worthy vessels and those who are not.
• The recurring formula with "may it be" (a wish construction) is an oath: should Akṣobhya break the vow, may he be counted as having deceived all the present buddhas. The term rendered "authorities" here is the word elsewhere meaning valid cognition; in this context it means a reliable standard or authority.
• The recurring oath formula, literally "may those buddhas be deceived (by me)," is an imprecation on oneself: should the vow be broken, one would stand guilty of having deceived all present buddhas. The word read here as "dream" is written with a variant spelling of the usual Tibetan term. In the vow about the buddhafield, the point is not that no women will be born there, but that women there will be free of the faults of women of the present age.
• The gods' second speech is addressed to "Venerable Blessed One," evidently the Buddha Great Eye in the past narrative. The phrase rendered "roots of virtue that are not of meager

worth" translates a Tibetan expression literally meaning "not possessing a poor purpose." The narrative formula after the gods' speech uses an honorific verb ("When this had been declared"), rendered neutrally.

• "Died a wretched death" renders a phrase that may also mean dying in a bad state of mind or an untimely death. "All the Vajrapāṇis" follows the Tibetan plural "whatever ... all of them," implying many Vajrapāṇis across the worlds of the trichiliocosm.

• The final phrase reads □□□□□□□□, literally "sound of a rainbow," which makes no sense here; it has been taken as a slip for □□□□□□□□□□, "sounds of laughter." The Kaumudī festival is the autumn full-moon festival named after the white water lily (kumuda), which the Tibetan calls "the kumuda festival."

• The phrase rendered "dwells, lives and abides" is the stock Tibetan formula for a buddha presently living in a world system; the syllable written □□□□ is the form usually found in this formula and is taken in that standard sense.

• "Have not yet entered the flawless state" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which most likely corresponds to Sanskrit niyāma or samyaktva-niyāma: the "fixed" or "faultless" state of certainty entered on the path of seeing. Here it refers to śrāvaka practitioners who have not yet reached that stage.

• The māras' thought is introduced by "why" (□□□□□□□□□), rendered here as the rhetorical "Why should we not overpower...?", that is, the intention to obstruct him never arose in them.

• The figure of the trunk's girth, "half a krośa," is given as the Tibetan states it, though it seems small relative to the other dimensions.

• The phrase rendered "is not inferior to the food of the gods" reads literally "does not ... to the food of the gods" with the verb □□□; the sense of falling short or comparing unfavorably is taken from context.

• "The precious woman" renders the strīratna, the queen who is one of the seven treasures of a universal monarch. The phrase rendered "compare ... with" contains the word □□□, which does not fit the syntax well. The translation follows the evident sense, that the qualities of the precious woman are being set against those of the women of Akṣobhya's field.

• The phrase rendered "laid down the cause for it beforehand" literally says that the guide "sent the cause ahead," meaning that Akṣobhya's own earlier practice set the pattern and created the cause for his people's conscientiousness.

• The phrase rendered "on the great earth" reads in the Tibetan as "from ... great"; this is taken as a scribal omission of the word for "earth," reading "the great earth," which the context plainly requires.

• The list of very large numerical units (khyad phyin, gtams, dkrigs, mchog yas, karanda, zil gnon, ther 'bum, "immeasurable") could not be matched with confidence to specific Sanskrit number names, so most are rendered by their literal meanings ("surpassings," "fullnesses," "enfoldings," "boundless supremes," "overpowerings"); "karanda" follows the Tibetan transliteration, and "ther-bum" is a Tibetan term for a very large number. In the list of arhat epithets, the term elsewhere glossed as "empowerment" here means "mastery" (vaśitā), as the context requires.

• "The four transgressions" refers to the four gravest offenses of monastic discipline (pārājika). The five degenerations listed (of lifespan, beings, the times, views, and afflictions) are the classical five kaṣāyas.

• The verb rendered "cause to subside" translates a phrase meaning "to settle, become latent, quietly disappear"; it describes the water and the body dissolving into space without falling. The chapter colophon gives the sūtra's title here as "The Prophecy of Akṣobhya."

• "Like the Buddha's going forth" renders sangs rgyas kyi bzhud pa; bzhud pa (honorific "going, departure") could also suggest the Buddha's manner of proceeding or conduct. "Linked" and "link" render mtshams sbyor ba, the term also used for rebirth-linking: these bodhisattvas will

never again take connection with the śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha levels.
• The piece opens with the close of a sentence whose subject (those born in Akṣobhya's field) was given in the preceding lines; it has been rendered as a complete sentence. The term rendered "harassment" (Tibetan mtho 'tsham pa) denotes seeking an opening to attack or disturb.
• "State of certainty" renders □□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. niyāma), the assured position of a bodhisattva destined for awakening. The clause about the māras "disparaging that name and that birth" is read from a terse Tibetan construction; it may alternatively mean they are reproached by that name and birth.
• The idiom rendered "will not become afraid in the slightest" literally reads "will not become afraid even once in a hundred times."
• The opening phrase is read as a man who has first taken an antidote and then drinks poison, which fits the simile of harmlessness; it could also be construed as a man who eats poison. The "golden pillar" renders a term for a sacrificial or offering pillar.
• "Falling into the lower realms" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. vinipāta), the fall into unfortunate destinies from which a stream-enterer is freed. The phrase "certainly bound for perfect awakening" follows the canonical description of the stream-enterer, where "awakening" means liberation. "Acceptance that phenomena are unborn" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (anutpattikadharmakṣānti).
• Ānanda's phrase "put to the test" renders a verb meaning literally "to rouse" or "to prompt"; he means to draw out Subhūti's eloquence. The future buddha's name is translated as "Golden Lotus"; its Sanskrit form (perhaps Kanakapadma or Suvarṇapadma) cannot be fixed with confidence.
• The epithets "who has become the eye, wisdom, the sovereign, the standard of what is valid, the light" render a string of "-bhūta" style epithets; "sovereign" for □□□□□□□□□□□□□ and "standard of what is valid" for □□□□□□□□□□□□ are interpretive.
• □□□□□□□ beside □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is taken as the śrīvatsa, the auspicious mark usually paired with the svastika; it might also mean auspicious signs in general. The tree □□□□□□□ and the stone □□□□□□□ could not be securely identified, so their names are left as the Tibetan spells them. The tree is perhaps the tiniśa, and the stone perhaps musāragalva, but both identifications are uncertain.
• "A million great eons" renders "ten hundred-thousands of great eons." The "seat of awakening" renders the Tibetan for bodhimaṇḍa.
• The second bodhisattva's name, rendered here "Bullock Gandhahastin," is literally "Ox (or Bullock) Fragrant Elephant"; I could not identify a secure Sanskrit form for it, so the first element is translated literally. The "three aspects" refer to the threefold recollection of Akṣobhya's Dharma, his śrāvaka Saṅgha and his bodhisattvas described in the preceding sentences.
• The "three aspects" of the root of virtue appear to refer to the recollection of the Buddhas, the Dharma and the Saṅgha described in the passage, that is, the Three Jewels. The phrase rendered "never to fall into the lower states" corresponds to the Sanskrit idea of avinipātadharma.
• "Sets about depicting" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which as written is obscure; I have read it as □□□□□□□□□ ("showing, depicting"), i.e. making or displaying an image of Akṣobhya. The closing "not in respect of liberation" means the two assemblies of śrāvakas differ in number, not in the liberation they attain. Here □□□□□□□□□□□□□, listed between once-returning and arhatship, is rendered "non-returning" as the third fruit of the śrāvaka path. In the list of fractions, □□□□ (koṭi, ten million) is multiplied out: a hundred koṭis is a thousand million, a thousand koṭis ten thousand million, and a hundred thousand koṭis a million million. The last item, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, is taken as a hundred thousand koṭi-niyutas, the niyuta

being left untranslated as a large number whose value varies between sources.
• The closing phrase of the second comparison, "yet it is not with respect to liberation that they differ," renders a terse clause. It appears to mean that the superiority of Akṣobhya's śrāvakas lies in their number, not in any difference in the liberation they attain. The last term of the fixed comparison formula is rendered "cause" in keeping with the glossary. In the standard Sanskrit formula it corresponds to upaniṣad, there meaning "remote resemblance."
• The idiom "a good year" (lo legs pa) means an abundant harvest; the "good year of the true Dharma and of the Saṅgha" plays on this as the remedy for the "famine of the true Dharma." The identification of the individual pulses (peas, chickpeas, lentils) is approximate.
• "They will not pass beyond the time of a second perfectly complete buddha" renders an idiom meaning that such practitioners will attain arhatship no later than the dispensation of the next buddha. "Compelling reason" renders a phrase that here means "benefit" or "compelling reason" (Skt. arthavaśa), not empowerment. The phrase "practice it as yoga in accordance with suchness" is literal; the underlying sense may simply be "apply themselves to it in just that way."
• The number of buddhas yet to appear in the Fortunate Eon is given as 996, presumably the thousand buddhas of this eon minus the four who have already appeared, Śākyamuni being the fourth.
• The phrase rendered "lend" reads bkur du, which does not fit the context; it is taken as a slip for a verb meaning "to lend" (the book having just been borrowed, brnyas). Likewise 'dri phod, literally "dare to ask," is read as 'bri phod, "dare to write," since the following lines all concern copying the text.
• The statement "it is one bodhisattva great being who fully awakens, not two" is terse in the Tibetan. It may mean that only one bodhisattva attains awakening at a time in a given field, or that the path of awakening is one and not twofold. It has been translated literally. The phrase rendered "koṭis of niyutas" stands for a standard compound of very large numbers.
• Śakra's thought is rendered as the Tibetan states it: "These are gods." Other versions of this sūtra report the opposite judgment, that these beings are humans, but the translation follows this text as it stands. The "fourfold assembly" refers to monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen.
• Kauśika is a clan name used as an epithet of Śakra (Indra). The Tibetan does not specify which tathāgata gives the prophecy to those who made aspirations; it may be Śākyamuni or Akṣobhya, and the translation leaves this unstated as the text does.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.